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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

CHRISTMAS DAY GREETINGS

RSS
Kathmandu, Dec. 25

President Ramchandra Paudel and Vice President Ram Sahay Prasad Yadav have wished for happiness, peace and good health to all Christians on the occasion of the Christmas Day.

In a message of greetings, the President said that this festival would help further strengthen our national unity.

The President was of the view that mutual goodwill, tolerance and solidary among diverse cultural identities and religious values would help further strengthen our national unity. President Paudel has added that this festival would deepen aspiration of mutual trust, affection and unity among Nepalis and could make a prosperous Nepal.

In a separate message of greetings, the Vice President has said that the Christmas festival is a social and cultural celebration like other festivals being observed in Nepal.

Similarly, Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has extended best wishes to all Christian communities living in the country and abroad on the occasion of the Christmas Day.

Giving a message of best wishes, PM Prachanda expressed belief that the Christmas will help foster national unity, religious tolerance and social harmony. He reminded that Nepal's constitution has incorporated multicultural diversity. It is common responsibility of all of us to promote unity and tolerance among diverse caste, culture, religion, language and communities, PM Prachanda viewed.

Similarly, the Head of the Government further reminded that globalization has caused intense connectivity and assimilation of human from different countries, communities and cultures across the globe.

LUMBINI CABINET EXPANDED

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Rupandehi, Dec. 24

Lumbini Province Council of Ministers was expanded on Sunday.

Lumbini Province Chief Minister Dilli Bahadur Chaudhary expanded the Council of Ministers by adding two ministers seven months after his appointment as Chief Minister. Now, the province has nine ministers in total.

Krishna KC from CPN (Maoist Centre) has been appointed as Minister of Water Supply, Rural and Cooperatives Development while Saroj Thapa of Nepali Congress has been appointed as Minister for Tourism and Transport.

Lumbini Provincial Chief Amik Sherchan administered the oath of office and secrecy to the new ministers.



PHOTO: PM'S SECRETARIAT

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' directing ministers and officials of Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation and Ministry of Water Supply at a review meeting held in Singha Durbar, Kathmandu on Sunday.

Loan shark victims get back more than 218 bigha of land

BY PURUSHOTTAM P. KHATRI
Kathmandu, Dec. 24

The government's initiatives and actions have now moved towards permanently resolving the cases related to the problems of loan sharking.

The Commission formed to address loan-sharking problems in April this year submitted its report to the government on December 12.

Uttamraj Subedi, one of the members of the Commission and also the Additional Inspector General of Police, shared that since the formation of the Commission, a total of 218 bigha, 10 kattha and 7 dhur (147.6 hectares) of land has been returned to the loan shark victims from their usurious lenders through reconciliation.

The Commission had collected applications from the victims from April 30 to May 28, after it formally began its work from April 9. Altogether 21,552 complaints were lodged from eight districts in Madhes Province while 1,862 complaints were filed from Nawalparasi West.

Commission Chairman Gauri Bahadur Karki said there was no problem of usury in 39 districts.

The government had formed a three-member high-powered Commission to address the issues of loan sharking. The Parliament also had passed the law regarding this and the law has been enforced as well.

The alleged loan sharks who had initially asked for as much as Rs 7.62 billion, have settled for only Rs 1.72 billion during negotiations facilitated by the Commission.

Road to Justice

Over 5,000 cases resolved

According to the Commission, it settled as many as 5,188 complaints of 27,582 through compromise deals. Most complaints originated in eight districts of the Madhes, and the Commission has settled most of these complaints through compromise.

It could settle as many as 3,689 complaints through compromise. As many as 643 complaints were settled in Bara alone, the highest in a district.

Most lenders not only agreed to settle for lower amounts than mentioned in the mortgage documents but also to return the lands the victims claimed were unjustifiably seized by inflating the loan amounts.

According to the Commission, the total loan amount mentioned in the personal mortgage documents in its possession is Rs. 5.57 billion. As a part of the settlement, the lenders also agreed to return over 218 bighas (147.6 hectares) of land which was allegedly seized by artificially inflating loan amounts to the borrowers.

The Commission had little time to settle all the complaints, given the significantly high number, and in many cases, lenders have refused to resolve disputes through compromise.

The Commission suggested the government authorises concerned chief district officers to continue settling disputes through compromise decrees.

Bill criminalises loan sharking

The government, in May, introduced an ordinance criminalising the practice of loan sharking, which greatly helped the Commission settle disputes through compromise between the two sides.

When the ordinance was in force, the Commission warned the lenders that they could be prosecuted if they didn't opt for a compromise.

"As a result, many loan sharks had agreed to settle disputes by withdrawing court cases and promised to return the lands they had seized from borrowers," Karki said.

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PM emphasises on transparent aircraft purchase deal

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 24

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has instructed the Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation (MoCTCA) not to make any errors or create disputes in the procurement process of aircraft this time and to be more transparent in the process.

Speaking at a joint briefing and discussion with the MoCTCA and the Ministry of Water Supply (MoWS) at the Singh Durbar on Sunday afternoon, PM Prachanda has warned the Ministry not to repeat the past mistakes and push the procurement process into a controversy.

"Procurement of aircraft had always been an issue of controversy and multiple questions were raised every time. I want you not to make a mistake this time. The procurement process should be completely accurate and transparent," he said.

PM Prachanda maintained that some of the policy provisions are not tourist-friendly, so the country should create a comfortable environment for tourists by reforming such policies.

He directed the MoCTCA to bring a proposal to make the necessary changes in the policies.

"Let us attract tourists by opening the prohibited areas. Night service should also be facilitated in tourist areas and the government should be flexible in such initiatives," said PM Prachanda.

He said that on the one hand, negativism has increased so much in the country that no matter how good things are and done, it would be criticised.

"The disease of not seeing the good is increasing. The audience has also become happy with negative words and insults. Apolitical forces with no background, no contribution and no goal are trying to take direct advantage of it. We have to change this situation," he said.

Minister for Water Supply Mahindra Ray Yadav, Minister for Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation Sudan Kirati, Minister of State of Tourism, Sushila Sripali, Chief Secretary of the Government of Nepal Dr. Baikunth Aryal, Secretary of the MoWS Suresh Acharya, Secretary of MoCTCA Deepak Kafle, Finance Secretary Krishna Hari Pushkar and others officials participated in the meeting.

OFFICIALS ASKED TO SOLVE WATER SUPPLY PROBLEM

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 24

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has instructed to solve the water supply problem immediately.

He directed the officials of the Ministry of Water Supply and the Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation to waive the bills of consumers who do not receive water in their taps.

The Prime Minister stated, "I understand that the work in Melamchi is progressing rapidly. A 28-day compact action plan has been created, covering a strategy to deliver 170 million litres of water to Sundarijal within a month. Currently, the work is underway in two shifts. In line with this, the Ministry of Water Supply's leadership and all teams are expected to engage with particular diligence."

He said, "The Kathmandu Valley now has a demand for 250 million litres of water per day. We have also identified and worked on other sources besides Melamchi. Currently, a feasibility study is being conducted to divert 110 million litres of water from the Sisneri River in Makwanpur to the Kathmandu Valley. The ministry will speed up this work as well."

"In the hilly and mountainous areas, women have to fetch water from far away which makes them prone to uterine prolapse, the Ministry needs to bring a proposal to address these issues," said PM Prachanda.

In the meeting, Minister for Water Supply Mahendra Ray Yadav highlighted the necessity of structural improvements in water supply projects. He expressed the need for simplifying the Public Procurement Regulation, addressing legal issues, and attracting the international community interested in investing in drinking water projects.

He said that a reserve tank should be built in Chure to recharge the Chure area and emphasised that drinking water that is being wasted from stone taps (Dhungedhara) in Kathmandu should be utilised.

Similarly, the Minister for Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation, Sudan Kiranti said that the airports built under political pressure have not been successful and in the future, airports should be built only based on actual need.

Media should bridge govt and people: Minister Sharma



BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Biratnagar, Dec. 24

Minister for Communication and Information Technology Rekha Sharma has said that the state-owned media should work to build a communication bridge between the people and the government.

After a site visit of the Gorkhapatra Corporation Biratnagar Publication House on Sunday, Minister Sharma pointed out the need for the state-owned media to bring to light people's concerns and aspirations while also covering the government's works and efforts to meet people's aspirations. Stating that such media were more sovereign and freer, she said that they should be more accountable to the public.

Stating that it was crucial to change public opinion towards the state-owned media, Minister Sharma said that one should pay special attention to the content included in the media to change public opinion.

She said that the government was in the process of the formulation of the Public Broadcast Act to bring Radio Nepal and Nepal Television together. She said that due to the lack of factual information, negative perceptions towards state-owned media were being spread and the media were lacking accountability.

Minister Sharma stressed the need for debate on democracy and management, inclusiveness and constitution by Gorkhapatra including other media.

Gorkhapatra Corporation's Acting Chairman Bishnu Prasad Subedi said that they were working in constant discussions with the government by prioritising the task of making Gorkhapatra accountable to the public and making it business and technology-friendly.

The General Manager of the Gorkhapatra Corporation, Lal Bahadur Airi, apprised Minister Sharma of the works done by the corporation's Biratnagar Publications House.

He said that the corporation would achieve commercial success if legal obstacles to operating a modern offset press with full capacity were removed.

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Wildlife menace common near Shivapuri National Park

BY INDIRA ARYAL
Sundarijal, Dec. 24

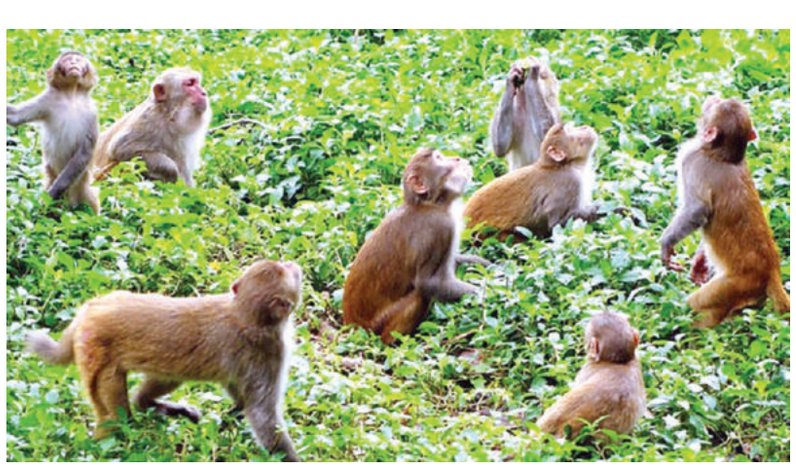
People living in the vicinity of Shivapuri National Park near the capital city are troubled by wildlife menace. They have been dealing with the problems caused by monkeys and wild boars as the farmers of the remote villages.

Because of the expanding forest cover in buffer zones around Shivapuri Nagarjun National Park, the locals are susceptible to the increasing threats posed by wildlife.

The locals are voicing their frustration over the ongoing wildlife menace and the lack of compensation for loss sustained over the past two years.

Sukamaya Gurung from Bhotechaur-3 in Sindhupalchowk district expressed her panic, "We have not received compensation for the damages caused to our crops by the wildlife for the last two years. Even if they offer relief, it is insufficient, they provide only up to Rs. 10,000 as a relief, which is not enough to cover the incurred loss."

"I planted maize in 16 ropanis of land last year, wild boars damaged the crops before we could harvest. Leopards and wild bears also invade our homes. The government should provide us with adequate relief, relocate us from the area, or manage the wildlife within the forest," she said.



Locals cannot go out of their houses alone fearing the leopards and bears, she added.

Meena Gurung of the same ward also has a similar story to share.

Last year, three goats were killed in a leopard attack, she recalled.

"Despite seeking compensation, we have received nothing. The ward chairman is in Manpokhari, and we have presented our problem many times, but our genuine concerns have not been addressed," she said.

"It is challenging for us to stay in the area. We are constantly facing threats from various wild animals, including the common leopard, Himalayan black bear, goral, wild boar, and porcupine. Let's not even mention monkeys, as they come in large numbers and cause havoc."

Surendra Gurung of Haibung in Melamchi Ward No. 3, said that if they could not be relocated from the area, they should be helped grow alternative crops that are resistant to damage from wild animals.

Some people in the village have opted for alternative cash crops like lemons and oranges, but not everyone is in a position to afford the plants, he added.

Narayan Shrestha of the Sundarijal-Shivapuri Consumer Committee said that all the area of the erstwhile Sundarijal Village Development Committee fall inside the buffer zone area. Among them, four villages – Okhreni, Kune, Chilaune and Mulkharka are inside the park.

Villagers complain that leopards and bears are frequently spotted near their houses, though they do not typically attack humans, they pose a threat to cattle. Monkeys and boars are causing immense damage to crops, he informed.

Dr. Ganesh Pant, Chief Conservation Officer of the Park, informed that the park is obligated to pay over Rs. 10 million in compensation annually. The park is in debt, owing Rs. 20 million in compensation for the last two years, which includes complaints from the Forest Office within its jurisdiction. "However, the park received only Rs. 2 million last year," he added.

Locals are currently receiving a maximum compensation of Rs. 10,000 per season for their losses, which is less than the actual damage incurred. Wild boars and monkeys are particularly affecting maize crops. Instances of such destruction have been documented in Kakani in Nuwakot, Gurje in Sindhupalchowk, and Sindhu-Shivapuri in Kathmandu, with reports of similar incidents in other areas as well.

He said that while the area has traditionally been a bear habitat, conflicts were rare until recently. Recent issues have surfaced outside the protected area in Gurjebahngyang, Nuwakot, leading residents to seek park assistance. In response, the park conducted monitoring, with no reported losses. However, a an incident occurred in Sundarijal during Dashain.

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Economy making positive headway

RSS
Kathmandu, Dec. 24



ONE YEAR OF GOVERNMENT

The economic condition of the country was not in good shape when the incumbent government led by Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' assumed its responsibilities a year ago.

The internal and external sectors of the national economy were under tremendous pressure due to the COVID-19 pandemic and the Russia-Ukraine war among others. Compared to the previous year, the economic indicators are moving towards a positive direction at present. Rays of hope could be seen in the financial and monetary sectors.

Immediately after the formation of the government, a meeting of the Council of Ministers convened on December 26, 2022, decided to proceed with economic reform at policy, procedure and institutional levels.

The reformative actions seemed to yield some desired results as well. The external sector is in comfortable condition while there has been a considerable increase in the remittance inflow and influx of foreign tourists. Improved indicators

Looking at the major economic indicators of the country during the past year, there are signs of improvement. The inflation has decreased in comparison with the last year.

The statistics of Nepal Rastra Bank (NRB) showed that consumer price inflation had remained at 7.38 per cent as of mid-December 2022. The inflation rate in the first four months of the current fiscal year stands at 5.38 per cent. The external sector was in bad shape last fiscal year. The total foreign exchange reserve was Rs. 129.56 billion. The foreign exchange reserve was able to cover 10 months of import of goods and 8.7 months of imports of goods and services.

The foreign reserve exchange as of mid-November this fiscal year is Rs. 169.6 billion. Considering the import of the last four months of the current fiscal year, it seems that the current foreign exchange reserve could cover 13.6 months of import of goods and 11.4 months of import of goods and services.

Similarly, there has been a noticeable improvement in the arrival of foreign tourists and remittance inflow compared to the last year. Over 954,000 foreigners visited Nepal in the last 11 months of 2023. The remittance inflow increased by 26.4 per cent and reached Rs. 477.96 billion in the first four months of the current fiscal year.

The balance of payment is at a surplus of Rs. 147.11 billion.

The government has heeded the repeated requests made by the entrepreneurs to consider reducing the bank interest rate. The inter-transaction rate of the banks and financial institutions is, thus, declining lately. The weighted average inter-bank transaction among the banks was 8.50 per cent as of mid-November last fiscal year. It has come down to 3.47 per cent during the same period this fiscal year. After the first quarterly review of the existing monetary policy, Nepal Rastra Bank (NRB) reduced the bank rate from 7.5 per cent to 7 per cent while the policy rate fell from 6.5 per cent to 5.5 per cent.

It has been taken positively by the businesspersons and industrialists, for they had demanded it for long.

However, the rising public debt and deficit budget are worrying issues in the Nepali economy. In the first quarter of the current fiscal year alone, Nepal witnessed an increase of the public debt of Rs. 57.71 billion.

Coupled with this is the inability to increase capital expenditure. The revenue failing to meet regular expenses is equally upsetting. These are important areas the government needs adequate attention. Till mid-December, the government has been able to collect only 26.07 per cent of the target revenue for the year.

Meanwhile, the government has taken significant decisions on infrastructure developments this past year. The decision to forward the constructions of Budhigandaki and Karnali Chisapani Reservoir-based Hydropower Projects is taken positively.

Similarly, taking ahead the Upper Arun and Dudhkoshi Hydropower Projects are other welcome initiatives. The national pride project, Pokhara Regional International Airport, was inaugurated on January 1, 2023.

The installed hydropower capacity has so far reached 28,000 MW in Nepal, which is enough to cover 94 per cent of demand in the country. Of late, the government has intensified the process of exporting the surplus power.

Moreover, PM Prachanda paid official visits to India and China last year. Many important agreements were signed during the visits. An understanding was reached to forward a process for tripartite agreement after agreement in principle to start the export of electricity produced in Nepal to Bangladesh via India.

During the visit, an agreement was signed to sell 10,000 MW of electricity to India in 10 years from Nepal as well as to finalise the detailed project report of the Pancheshwor multi-purpose project within three months.

Similarly, an agreement was reached to amend Nepal-India Transit treaty in the course of India visit as well as expand the petroleum pipeline from Amalekhgunj of Bara to Lothar of Chitwan and Siliguri of India to Charali of Jhapa with financial and technical support of India.

Likewise, Nepal and India signed a memorandum of understanding related to cross-border digital payment.

Prime Minister Prachanda embarked on a China visit in the third week of September and the two countries signed various agreements for cooperation in different sectors. Both countries have agreed to collaborate in inter-state infrastructure development, trade promotion and facilitation, expansion of diplomatic relations and regional cooperation.

Similarly, an agreement was reached to take 'BRI Implementation Project' soon to a conclusion to forward the agreement signed on May 12, 2017, for bilateral collaboration as per 'Belt and Road Initiative Framework'.

Both sides agreed to build a 'Trans-Himalayan Multi-Dimensional Connectivity Network' as well as to reopen Nepal-China check points. China and Nepal made the understanding to give final shape to 'Nepal-China Electric Power Co-operation Plan' as well as to initiate the activities of 200-kV. Jilong-Kerung-Rasuwagadhi-Chilime Inter-state Transmission Line as soon as possible.

Meanwhile, the government has made preparations to organise investment summit in Kathmandu from April 21, 2024. A directive committee under the coordination of the Finance Minister, an implementation committee under the coordination of the Chief Secretary and a technical committee under the coordination of the Secretary of the Ministry of Industry, Commerce and Supplies were formed to organise the investment summit.

TESLA TO BUILD AN ENERGY-STORAGE FACTORY IN CHINA

AP
Beijing, Dec. 24

American electric automaker Tesla's plans to produce energy-storage batteries in China moved forward on Friday with a signing ceremony for the land acquisition for a new factory in Shanghai, China's state media said. Construction is scheduled to start early next year with production to come on line by the end of the year, the official Xinhua News Agency said.

The factory won't build batteries for cars but for electric utilities and other companies to store power. Such storage units have become increasingly important with the growth in solar and wind energy, which only generate electricity when weather conditions are favorable and need to store it for when residential and commercial users need it.

The new factory will initially produce 10,000 of Tesla's Megapack units annually for sale worldwide, Xinhua said. The Tesla project is a rare piece of good news for the Chinese economy, which has seen a sharp drop in foreign investment this year. The Commerce Ministry said this week that foreign investment in the first 11 months of this year was down 10% compared with the same period last year.

Foreign companies are worried about the Chinese government's increasing control over business on national security and other grounds, as well as growing U.S. restrictions on technology trade with China.

China is a major market and manufacturing center for Tesla, and the company's CEO, Elon Musk, has built close ties with Chinese officials even as U.S.-China relations soured. In May, he met the commerce minister and the then-foreign minister in Beijing.

Jasmine Paints completes 30 years in operation

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 24

Jasmine Paints has completed three decades in operation.

Brothers-trio Gunanidhi Aryal, Laxman Aryal and Madhusudan Aryal from Bharatpur of Chitwan had launched the company in 1994 seeing an opportunity in the business as the housing sector had begun to flourish then.

Jasmine Paints, which started with a simple family background and simple investment, has now succeeded in becoming one of the best in the field of the domestic paints industry, the company said in a statement.

According to Aryal, 1,000 dealers from around 60 districts across the country are helping to promote the business of Jasmine Paints. Currently, more than 200 people are directly employed by the industry.

The industry has recently entered into a technology collaboration partnership with the Taiwan-based Innovation Technology Paints Company Limited. Likewise, in future, it plans to introduce new technology and better products in the market as per the demand of the consumers. The production capacity has gone up to 20 tonnes per day.

According to Madhusudan Aryal, a director of the company, investment in the industry has now reached more than Rs. 1 billion. Meanwhile, the company's products have received ISO quality mark - 9001:2000 certification.

Similarly, Jasmine Paints has received 'International BID Quality Achievement Gold Award-London' and 'Nepal Best Brand Leadership Award-2018' in 2018. Bharatpur Metropolitan Corporation has also awarded it as the best industry and the best taxpayer in that area.

Jasmine Paints' popular products include 'Cool Paints', Royal Glaze, Weather Care for exterior walls and Home, Trim, Majolica Emulsion for interior walls. Similarly, enamel, distemper, primer, dam control necessary for coloring are also being produced.

Foreign trade falls in first five months

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 24



The country's foreign trade has decreased during the first five months of the current fiscal year 2023/24.

According to the foreign trade statistics of the Department of Customs, foreign trade has decreased by 3.64 per cent to Rs. 705.41 billion during the first five months of the current fiscal year.

A decline in both exports and imports has contributed to a fall in foreign trade during the review period. Imports have decreased by 3.39 per cent during the first five months of the current fiscal year. Goods worth Rs. 642.20 billion were imported in the review period. The country imported goods worth Rs. 664.74 billion in the same period last fiscal year.

Not only imports but also exports have decreased during the review period. Goods worth Rs. 63.20 billion have been exported in five months of the current fiscal year. Goods worth Rs. 67.30 billion were exported in the first five months of the last fiscal year.

Although exports decreased by 6.09 per cent, there was some improvement in the overall trade deficit in the first five months of the current fiscal year.

The country faces a trade deficit of Rs. 579 billion. This trade deficit is less by 3.09 per cent compared to the same period last year.

During the review period, the export has decreased due to a fall in the export of soybean and palm oil.

The country has exported soybean oil only worth Rs. 363 million in the first five months of the current fiscal year while soybean oil worth Rs. 6.98 billion was exported in the first five months of the last fiscal year. Similarly, palm oil worth Rs. 2.47 billion has been exported in the first five months of the current fiscal year while it exported palm oil worth Rs. 10.87 billion during the same period last fiscal year.

During the review period, tea and coffee worth Rs. 1.88 billion, carpet worth Rs. 4.86 billion, yarchhagumba worth Rs. 553 million, dog or cat food worth Rs. 1.18 billion and yarns worth Rs. 4.82 billion were exported.

In the meantime, the import of crude palm and soybean oil has reduced during the first five months of the current fiscal year. The crude palm oil worth Rs. 6.61 billion, crude soybean oil worth Rs. 7.24 billion and sunflower oil worth Rs. 6.83 billion were imported during the review period.

In the first five months of the current fiscal year, petrol worth Rs. 28.55 billion, diesel worth Rs. 53.90 billion, aviation fuel worth Rs. 8.66 billion and liquefied petroleum gas worth Rs. 20.65 billion have been imported.

Similarly, the country imported paddy and rice worth Rs. 8.24 billion, maize worth Rs. 4.95 billion and wheat worth Rs. 4.31 billion.

Ichchhakamana farmers earn 100 million from orange



RSS
Chitwan, Dec. 24

Farmers in Ichchhakamana rural municipality are poised to make bountiful earning from orange farming alone. More than 450 farmers in the rural municipality are set to earn Rs 100 million this year alone from the sale of oranges, according to the Agriculture Development Section of the rural municipality.

The oranges produced by farmers have fetched a good price this year, thus resulting in huge income. Section Chief Ashish Tripathi said a kilo of orange fetches Rs 75 to Rs 90 at the farmer's orchard at present. Orange is grown on 80 hectares of land in Ichchhakamana rural municipality this year and of this area, oranges have been produced in 60 hectares area. Tripathi said 15,000 out of the 20,000 orange trees grown in the rural municipality produced fruits. "The production is less this year compared to the previous year. Although the production is small, the farmers good a good price this year. Last year, 5,100 orange trees were planted under the Orange Growing Area Expansion Programme launched by the Agriculture Knowledge Centre (AKC). So, the orange plantation area expanded this year as compared to the last year, but the area with higher production did not expand.

According to him, orange production this year has declined by 12 percent compared to the production last year. The production last year was 1,650 metric tonnes and the production this year is 1, 500 metric tonnes.

Orange farming is done in Ichchhakamana rural municipality and in Bharatpur Metropolitan City-29, the two hilly areas of Chitwan district.

GUPTESHWAR CAVE EARNS MORE 50 MILLION IN YEAR

RSS
Gandaki, Dec. 24

The Gupteshwar Mahadev Cave in Chhorepatan, Pokhara, has earned Rs.54.2 million in one year. The historic, religious and tourist site is a popular site among tourists visiting Pokhara.

According to the information shared at the 28th Annual General Meeting of Gupteshwar Mahadev Cave Conservation Committee, Rs. 42.8 million was collected from ticket sales, Rs. 2.7 million from the donation box, Rs. 5.1 million from donation receipts, Rs. 1.6 million from bank interest and others from rented-out business complexes and membership, among others.

Chief Judge of Pokhara High Court, Madhav Prasad Pokharel, while inaugurating the AGM on Saturday, emphasised that the income of the religious sector should be invested in the development of education, health and society as a whole.

At the function, Gandaki Provincial Assembly Secretary Hariram Pokhrel and Dhanusha District Judge Yognath Dhakal were honoured for their contribution in the conservation of the cave.

ICT Award presented in 14 categories

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 24

The eighth edition of the ICT Award 2023 has honoured best professionals and institutions in the sector in 14 categories and the best startups the provinces.

The award was given by choosing the winners after five different stages of selection from more than 700 online applications. The winner of the South Asia Startup ICT Award 2023, organised as an international award, was also announced at the ceremony, informed the organiser, Living with ICT.

Balkrishna Joshi, the first e-commerce director, received this year's Pioneer ICT Award 2023. Sunaina Ghimire Pandey has received the Ncell Woman Icon ICT Award. Likewise, the Professional Excellence ICT Award has been received by Lochan Lal Amatya, President of Enren.

Anoop Serchan, CEO of Inficare, received the Entrepreneur's ICT Award while Nepali Diaspora ICT Award has been given to Prof Dr. Suresh Manandhar.

In institutional award categories, Nepal Stock Exchange (NEPSE) received the Digital Governance Award while the Digital Services ICT Award was awarded to the Tilganga Eye Foundation.

Similarly, Digital Education ICT Award (Public Sector) went to Tanahu's Satyadevi Secondary School and the Digital Education ICT Award (Private Sector) to Addhyan School of Kathmandu.

In the startup and innovation categories, Yarsa Tech received the 'InDrive Startup ICT Award this year, while Quick RPA got the Product ICT Award. Rising Star Innovation ICT Award was won by Blanxer. 'Money Mitra' has won the title of Hamro Pay Public Choice ICT Award. Bhutan's group Mediatech received the title of South Asia Startup ICT Award 2023 which was aimed at South Asian countries.

Apart from this, Living with ICT also honoured the seven best startups from all seven provinces with the IFN Province Startup ICT Recognition. They include Track on Nepal from Koshi Province, Ads Bee Media from Madhes Province, Heartson Technology from Bagmati Province, Restro X from Gandaki Province, Tuna Technology from Lumbini Province, Bio Karnali Aroma Pvt. Ltd. from Karnali and Neem Infosys from Sudurpaschim.

Water in Madhes contains hazardous iron, arsenic

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Dhalkewar, Dec. 24

The water testing laboratory of the Federal Water Supply and Sewerage Management Project in Janakpur has tested the samples of water collected from different places in the Madhes Province and found that the trace of iron was more than mandatory in the tested samples.

Krishna Kumar Sah, Head of the laboratory, said that in the fiscal year 2079/80, the amount of iron was found higher than the national drinking water quality standards when tests were conducted on the 1,288 samples collected from different places of the eight districts of the province.

He informed that in 137 samples tested in the current fiscal year, the iron content was found higher than the national drinking water quality standards.

The national drinking water quality standard mentions that there should be a maximum of 0.3 mg of iron per litre of drinking water, but according to chemist Sah, up to 0.8 mg of iron was found per litre in the tested water sources.

According to Sah, water samples collected from 673 tube wells of the community schools, health posts and ward offices, 150 samples received from the drinking water projects and 500 samples obtained from the water testing laboratories were tested.



FILE PHOTO: TRN

Woman drinking water from the hand-pump.

In the tested samples, 62.8 per cent iron content was found. Similarly, 32.6 per cent of mud and 16.04 per cent of manganese contents were also found. Sah informed that although a small amount of iron is beneficial for health, an excess amount is harmful. "When there is more iron, the colour of the water and taste change. Water contains a strange smell, and yellow stains gradually settle on white clothes," added Sah.

Manoj Adhikari, assistant chemist expert of the laboratory, said that more iron was found in the drinking water of Saptari district compared to other districts. He informed that traces of iron and arsenic were found in the water of more than 80 per cent of the tube wells. Federal Water Supply and Sewerage Management Project, Janakpur, has also conducted a tour service to check the quality of drinking water in Madhes Province.

A mobile service has been conducted to test the quality of water with a technical team and state-of-the-art equipment. In the last fiscal year, a team reached different places in all eight districts of Madhes Province and tested the water in 788 places, informed the head of the laboratory. Adhikari said, "We suggest people purify water before drinking if the trace of iron and arsenic is more than recommended by WHO."

Ghale group smuggled 138 kg of gold in five months: Probe panel

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 24

The probe committee formed after the seizure of 14 kg of smuggled gold by the Tribhuvan Airport Customs Office concluded that Min Bahadur Ghale and his group had smuggled 138 kg of gold in five months. Of that, only 14 kg of gold was seized by the customs office.

On December 8, Chandra Ghale, who came to Kathmandu from Dubai, was arrested by the customs office with 14 kg of gold. Later, Min Bahadur Ghale of Gorkha, who had used Chandra as a mule, was also arrested on the same day.

According to Mani Ram Paudel, chief of the probe committee and chief of the TIA Customs Office, their investigation has shown that Min Bahadur had been in regular contact and communication with a person named Ankit Agarwal in Dubai and arranged to smuggle gold to Nepal.

The investigation committee said, "On different dates, Min Bahadur Ghale, Chandra Ghale and Krishna Kumar Shrestha brought a total of 138 kg of gold and took it out from the airport by arranging the secret settings inside the airport."

Min Bahadur and Chandra along with Krishna Kumar Shrestha used to bring gold from Dubai. It has been found that Dan Bahadur Gurung, alias DB, was used to arrange the settings at the airport.

The committee concluded that air conditioner mechanic Radhakrishna Shrestha of Gauchar, office assistant Lek Bahadur Tamang, former contract employee Ramesh Deula, office assistant working in the AC branch Anil Shrestha and plumber Sher Bahadur Basnet played their role in sending the gold out from the airport.

Ramesh, Radhakrishna and Anil used to deliver the gold collected from the airport to DB Gurung's house in Suryadarshan Height, Baniyatar, Tokha Municipality, Kathmandu.

Thereafter, the collected gold used to be taken to the destinations by Min Bahadur and his friend Jeevan Gurung, alias Jane, as instructed by Ankit.

Phungling gives public holiday on Chasok festival Wednesday

BY CHANDRA PANDAK
Taplejung, Dec 24

Phungling Municipality in Taplejung district has decided to give a holiday on Wednesday to celebrate the Chasok Tangnam (Nwagi festival) of Kirant people.

People from the Limbu community in eastern Nepal celebrate the Chasok Tangnam festival. As Limbus are the major inhabitants within Phungling Municipality, the holiday has been given so that they can mark the festival.

According to a notice published by Prakash Poudel, the Acting Chief Administrative Officer of the municipality, on Sunday, on the occasion of the Chasok Tangnam, the first Kanchenjunga Seselung Gold Cup football tournament has also been organised, so the municipality decided to give a local holiday.

The office of Phungling Municipality, ward offices, health organisations, schools and other organisations remain closed on Wednesday, read the notice. With the Municipality declaring a local holiday on Wednesday now, Phungling locals will be having public holidays for three consecutive days.

Monday and Tuesday are national holidays. On Monday, it is Christmas, and on Tuesday, it is Udhauli festival. Meanwhile, on the occasion of the Chasok Tangnam festival, an inter-district level Kanchenjunga Seselung Gold Cup football competition has been organised in the district headquarters of Phungling by the Chasok Tangnam Management Committee.

Chandra Kumar Thebe, the coordinator of the committee, has informed that along with the football competition, competition programmes including paddy dance (Yahlang) and Chaybrung dance (Kehlang) based on Limbu culture have also been planned.

Airport will be built in Dharan: Mayor Rai



BY NISHA RAI
Dharan, Dec. 24

Dharan Sub-metropolitan City Mayor Harka Sampang Rai has said that an airport will be built and brought into operation smoothly in Dharan.

Speaking at a greetings exchange programme organised on the occasion of Udhauli, Chasok, Losar and Christmas in Dharan on Sunday, Mayor Sampang said that the airport should be built either by creating a necessary environment or amending the necessary laws.

He said that the land provided by Dharan residents had been neglected for years and middlemen had even started selling it. He said that disputes should not arise in the name of religion instead the followers of one religion should accept and respect the other.

Similarly, Dharan Sub-metropolitan City's Deputy Mayor Aindra Bikram Begha said that the sub-metropolis would not take sides of one religion as all religions and castes were considered equal by the state. He said that people with different ethnicities and religions had been living in peace and harmony in the country for a long time celebrating each other's cultures together.

Professor Dr. Tanka Neupane said that people must develop a sense of harmony instead of focusing on caste and religion. According to him, cultural deviation has occurred due to the lack of awareness and cultural values.

Dr. Rajendra Sharma, senior journalist Harsha Subba, Federation of Nepali Journalists Sunsari president Rishi Rai, Women Network Sunsari president Sapana Rai and others were present at the programme.

FRIENDSHIP INITIATIVE ANNOUNCED FOR THE GIRLS IN MADHESH

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 24

Minister for Health and Population Minister of Madhes Province Birendra Prasad Singh has initiated a friendship with local girls as part of a mission to create a girl-friendly environment in the region.

Teenage girls from a community school in Parsagadhi Municipality engaged in the 'I am a Child, Not a Bride' campaign recently met with Minister Singh and extended a friendship invitation, which he accepted.

Around 110 teenage girls formed a Vision Club focusing on discussions regarding menstrual hygiene, sexual and reproductive health rights, combating child marriage and enhancing child participation in schools. Madhu Yadav, the club's leader, emphasised that girl-centric conversations alone would not suffice in making the city and province more girl-friendly.

In a bid to support this objective, the girls formalised a friendship pact with Minister Singh, who expressed his commitment to addressing social, mental, and sexual health issues encountered by girls and teenagers in Madhesh Province.

The Integrated Rural Health Development Training Centre has been facilitating orientation programmes in Parsagarhi to raise awareness and enhance capacities among girls. Collaboratively, the Vision Club is spearheading a friendship initiative in Madhes Pradesh, aiming to create a safe space for girls to openly address their concerns.

NEWS BRIEF

Man dies in accident

Sarlahi: A man was killed in a motorcycle accident in Bishnu Rural Municipality-6 in Sarlahi district on Saturday night. In the accident, 20-year-old Indal Sahani of Kaudena Rural Municipality died. The accident took place after the driver lost control.

Sahani was heading towards Simara from Bhadsar on Saturday around 9:45 pm on a motorcycle with registration number BR 30 W 6390. The motorcycle hit an electricity pole. Sahani, who was taken to the Provincial Hospital, was pronounced dead while undergoing treatment.

Fire guts houses of refugee camp

Damak: Three houses were destroyed in the Bhutanese refugee camp in Damak, Jhapa, by a fire on Sunday morning. The fire broke out at the Beldangi Bhutanese refugee camp in Damak-3 around 3:00 am. According to the police, the fire broke out in thatched-roof hut No. 535 of Sector C (4), in which Bhim Bahadur Ghimire used to live, due to a short circuit.

Police have said that two other houses in his neighbourhood were also destroyed by the fire and all the clothes, and food items kept in those houses turned into ashes. District Police Office, Jhapa, said that the fire was brought under control after one hour with the help of a fire brigade of Damak Municipality.

TRN

Free eye camp in Halesi Tuwachung



PHOTO: RAJ KUMAR BHATTARAI/TRN

Locals getting free eye check-up in Khotang.

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Khotang, Dec. 24

In a three-day free eye camp organised in Halesi Tuwachung Municipality of Khotang district, 91 individuals have successfully undergone surgeries.

Locals who had cataracts went through operation at the Eye and Ear Treatment Centre in Halesi Bazaar from Thursday to Saturday and the eyelids of patients who underwent surgery were opened on Sunday.

Surendra Shrestha, head of Eye and Ear Treatment Centre, Halesi, said that 64 people underwent cataract surgery, while 27 others had a minor operation to remove growing flesh from their eyes and molluscum contagiosum. Likewise, 590 people have received free services in the three-day camp," added Shrestha.

"Free medicines were distributed to more than 400 people and spectacles were distributed to more than 150 people. Black spectacles were provided free of cost to 91 individuals who underwent surgery," said Shrestha.

People from Okhaldhunga, along with other municipalities including Rawa Besi Rural Municipality, Diktel Rupakot Mazhuwagadhi Municipality, Diprung Chuichumma Rural Municipality, Sokala Rural Municipality and other nearby municipalities came to Halesi for eye check-up.

The free eye camp was organised by Halesi Tuwachung Municipality, Nepal Netra Jyoti Sangh Khotang, Eye and Ear Treatment Centre, Halesi and Eye Treatment Centre Support Committee with the technical assistance of Sagarmatha Chaudhary Eye Hospital of Lahan.

The camp was formally inaugurated by Bimala Rai, Deputy Mayor of Halesi Tuwachung Municipality. Speaking at the inauguration programme Rai said that the municipality was conducting various programmes along with the eye camp for the treatment of the citizens. This was the second year in a row, the eye camp was organised in Halesi.

Beni to Dhorpatan road to be upgraded

RSS
Myagdi, Dec. 24

A project to open and upgrade the Beni-Darbang-Muna-Jaljala-Dhorpatan road has been launched. The construction of the road from Beni to Dhorpatan via Darbang-Muna-Jaljala connecting Taksera in East Rukum will reduce the distance by 70 kms from the Baglung section of the mid-hill highway, said Chairperson of Dhaulagiri Rural Municipality Premprasad Pun.

Upgrading the 50 km road from Beni to Muna to Khoria and the work of opening the road from Khoria to Dhorpatan has been progressed. A 19 km road to connect Khoriya to Jaljala is being constructed through a project worth Rs 30 million rupees.

The project to blacken the 24-km Beni-Darbang road and gravel the six-km Darbang-Dharapani road has reached its final stage, adds Pun. The rural municipality has prepared a detailed project report (DPR) with a budget estimate of Rs. one billion to black top the road from Darbang to Mareini and submitted it to the provincial government.

Geographically, the residents of Mangala, Malika and Dhaulagiri Rural Municipalities of Myagdi will benefit and the road will be of national importance in the long term, said Vice-chair of Dhaulagiri rural municipality Ramesh Pun Magar.

Warrant/Notice issued by the High Court Patan Lalitpur to the following individuals.

In relation to the application Writ No. 080-WO-0862 filed by the writ applicant Mr. Gokul Bahadur Rokaya against including you demanding to issue certiorari mandamus order and application Writ No. 080-WO-0911 filed by the writ applicant Mr. Gokul Bahadur Rokaya against including you demanding to issue certiorari mandamus order, this warrant/notice has been hereby issued according to the order of this Court dated 2080/09/02 BS (December 18, 2023 AD). Therefore, you are hereby noticed to submit your reply statement in writing by personally or through your power of attorney or representative pursuant to the laws within 15 (Fifteen) days except traveling period from the date of publication of this notice. Otherwise, shall be done pursuant to the laws. In addition, as the mentioned writ applications are enlisted in the case list for discussing on the date 2080/09/11 BS (December 27, 2023 AD) for purpose of issuing interim order, it is also to inform you to attend on the discussion of presentation. **Particulars :**

1. Spectrlite UK Limited, situating office at Kathmandu District, K. M. C. Ward No. 26 Lainchaur.....1
2. Axiata Group Barhad, situating at the same addres.....1

Done it on Monday, 2080 Poush 09 BS (December 25, 2023 AD) with best regards.

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

It is never too late to be what you might have been.

-- George Eliot

EDITORIAL

Fund For Biogas Plants

The domestic biogas (DBG) plant that is also known as gobar gas had caught the fancy of Nepali farmers in mid-1980. It was new technology and many people set up the plants that can be run with animal dung, human excreta and the natural materials. With subsidies from government and foreign donors, the construction of biogas plants gained momentum for decades. In view of increasing climate-induced natural disasters, this clean energy should be in priority of both the government and the donors. But a news report published in this daily Sunday discloses that the number of people opting for the biogas plants has vastly declined as the government cut subsidies and donors stopped funding for the construction of biogas plants. Moreover, the people have preferred Liquefied Petroleum Gas (LPG) to the biogas with the urban culture and practice reaching nook and cranny of the country.

People's migration to cities, rising construction costs and diminishing support has led to the decreased trend in the development of biogas plants, which is sustainable alternative renewable energy and low-carbon technology. At one point about 40,000 biogas plants were constructed annually in the country, but now the number has fallen to below 10,000. For the agricultural country like Nepal, this is indeed a bad news because the biogas plants are viable for the people engaged in livestock farming. Despite this, the government has planned to install 200,000 biogas plants in the fiscal year 2019/20 as per the 15th Periodic Plan. Likewise, 500 large-scale biogas (LBG) plants will be set up to replace about 40,000 tonnes of LPG. The installation of biogas plants is also the part of the government commitment to promoting clean energy as per the Paris Climate Agreement.

Under the second Nationally Determined Contribution (NDC) 2020, an additional 200,000 household biogas plants and 500 (LBG) plants will be installed by 2025. Currently there are altogether 419,779 domestic biogas plants and 348 large biogas plants. The Alternative Energy Promotion Centre (AEPC) aims to install 10,000 biogas plants this fiscal year 2023/24. It requires about Rs. 300 million to meet the target. But it has the budget of only Rs. 50 million for subsidy. The shortfall in budget is likely to impede the momentum to achieve the stated goal. At a time when the nations are switching to clean alternative energy globally, the donors are showing apathy when it comes to funding the biogas plants which entails a number of benefits, economically and environmentally. The Census of 2021 states that about three-fourth of Nepali households still rely on firewood or bio-fuel to cook their meal, which badly affects the health of women, children and elderly people as well as the environment.

Several studies have concluded that the use of biogas and improved cook stoves have considerably improved the health of women and children in the rural areas while checking the deforestation. AEPC, which is also a regulatory and implementing agency in the alternative energy sector, even claims that the spread of biogas technology has helped break the stereotypes related to caste, ethnicity and gender, thereby promoting inclusive, participatory, decentralised and balanced development. The biogas plants have replaced about 5 million LPG cylinders, which has saved around Rs. 10 billion. Once the biogas plants had revolutionised the rural areas as they provided clean energy with inexpensive means. The government grants covered more than half of the construction cost. It is imperative for policy makers, the government agencies and political parties to promote biogas plants to enhance clean energy and reduce import of LPG.

Practicing Sustainability

BRITTI ARYAL

We often hear the word 'sustainability' in our day-to-day life, but don't often understand the extent of the meaning. We all hear about going green to support the environment, taking organic foods, following sustainable product brands, sustainable clothing, and many more. Yet, many of us do not know the actual concept and meaning of sustainability. The word has become so common that it has created a vast confusion about what truly is sustainable and what is not. Sustainability is the concept of supporting ecological and economic aspects of healthy and happy living.

A broader understanding of real impacts on the environment is necessary for all of us to create a real impact and the sustainable practices make it happen. It presumes that the resources are finite and should be used conservatively prioritising the long-term consequences of resources. We humans completely rely on natural resources for survival. Ignoring sustainability can lead to greater exhaustion. Thus, understanding sustainability is very much needed to incorporate sustainable practices into our daily routine.

Everyone needs to understand the role they can play in achieving sustainability. Small and simple switches can also make a huge difference. It all starts with a willingness to look critically at everything you do in your daily life. Once you incorporate the concepts of reduce, reuse, and recycle, you start becoming more aware of how much waste you are producing in everyday life, what kind of products you are buying, and most importantly, how you can reuse the things you bought, how you can reduce your waste. Then you start actively trying to make better decisions for the Earth.

Purchasing products that are made from sustainable materials like bamboo, cotton, and things that are easily degradable and don't affect the environment now or in the future will help reduce environmental footprints. Making wiser food choices is always a better option. You have to look into your meal and think about where it comes from, how it was grown, how it was prepared, and most importantly, how it was packed. Then there are ways to minimise the waste. The small spaces around your houses can be utilised for growing your produce. Growing your vegetables not only saves money but also helps reduce fossil fuels. Supporting sustainable foods helps to create environmental balance.

Planting trees and supporting conservation efforts is the best way to promote sustainability. Planting trees in free spaces in our gardens and settlement areas not only helps reduce greenhouse gases but also protects and preserves natural habitats. Another impactful way for sustainability is sharing rides and using public transport when possible. Living close to your workplace contributes to lower carbon emissions while cutting transportation costs. You have to make better sustainable choices to ensure a healthy and prosperous future for all. Cutting down on unnecessary water usage and turning off the lights and electronics when not in use helps to conserve energy. This can reduce carbon emissions and tackle climate change.

With time and much-needed critical thinking, thrifty living best serves sustainability. Selling and donating unused and unwanted items gives the items a new purpose. It lowers the new production, reducing the waste. Cost savings from implementing such practices allow for a greater profit return. Sustainable practice has to become a more integral part of our daily experiences as it encompasses how natural systems work and limits overuse, reducing waste and yielding everything required for the environment to remain in balance now and in the future. We must make the world a better place to live in, and practicing sustainability makes it possible.

The Lure Of Electoral Office



P Kharel

TIDE OF TIMES

El Salvador's President Nayib Bukele, 42, has technically withdrawn from the presidency. Clearly, he has sounded the bugle for his candidacy to the high post that elections will decide probably by next June. The country's Constitution does not allow more than a single term to a president. The Central American state of seven million people in the land of volcanoes and frequent earthquakes installed Bukele in office on June 1, 2019. El Salvador's Supreme Court has given a verdict that a president out of office for a period of at least six months is eligible to run for a fresh term. This is how Bukele seeks to circumvent the spirit of the fundamental law of the land.

More than half of the 67 million eligible Egyptian voters in a country of 110 million last fortnight went to the polls to decide who their executive head of state would be. Incumbent President Abdel Fattah el-Sissi registered a comfortable victory to rule for another six years.

A career military officer, el-Sissi led a military overthrow of an elected Islamist president and was elected president in 2014 and also in 2018 with baffling ease. In an interesting twist in 2019, constitutional amendments were introduced and approved in a national referendum, which awarded two additional years to his second term. The new laws allowed him to run for a third term. Thousands of his critics have suffered intimidation and thousands of others jailed. That Arab world's most populous country's economy is in a shambles did not change the electoral results, though.

Lost in lust

Avid attraction to power and its attendant official trappings prompt some of those at the helm of public affairs to retain and prolong their stay through machinations. Limited term to an executive head envisages self-check on temptations to misuse position and bend existing regulations. However, in practice, principles get sidelined frequently. The United States is the first country that established the practice of no more than two terms for any president — a precedent set by its founder President George Washington.

Efforts to breach the precedent later on were unceremoniously defeated. In 1952, the world's shortest constitution was amended to formally offer no more than two consecutive terms to anyone holding the nation's top job. In the 1980s, a trend took hold to bar individuals from holding more than a fixed number of years in office. The single- or two-term constitutional ceiling became mandatory.

Misuse of office by elected executive heads of state, including unbecoming manipulation and dubious means, gave compelling reasons to people for having fixed terms so that the best side of an elected leader might get the better of him or her without. It was hoped that the elected executive head might thus have little incentive to compromise decisions and get involved in machinations with constant sight on extensions in the high office they begin to get addicted to.

Two South East Asian nations in the 1980s drew much world attention when they, almost back-to-back, had approved constitutions that allowed only a single term to their elected presidents. Following the 1986 People Power movement, led by assassinated leader Benigno Aquino's widow Corazon Aquino, Filipinos had a new Constitution that allowed a fixed term of six years to a president. This was a direct outcome of the experience they had under the just ousted President Ferdinand Marcos, who went on self-exile on the advice of the US.

> By the time people realise having been taken for a complete ride, their tide of disenchantment fuels frustrations at formidable levels.

After Marcos became elected in December 1965, he grossly misused state machinery for enriching his family and coterie. His greed for power made him shed all qualms about throwing to the winds the ethical standards expected of the high office. Yet Marcos won election after election, even as popular disenchantment soared. Money power and other fraudulent methods combined to get him elected. The 1985 election was widely believed to have been rigged to the extent that massive crowds joined demonstrations on the streets of Manila for days until the Marcos family and his close relatives left for Hawaii, where the US gave him

Trying to cast aside the original spirit of the popular movement and the framing of the Constitution, Corazon Aquino who served as interim president and got elected for a four-year term was not satisfied even after staying in power for six years. She made moves to amend the Constitution to allow her contest for another term. A storm of protests against the bid made her to back out quickly.

Aquino endorsed Vice-President Gen. Fidel Ramos to succeed her. The army general, who had joined the People Power Revolution as it gained massive momentum on the streets of Manila against Marcos, was elected president. As his four-year term came close to end, he, too, nursed a desire for another term, only to drop it amidst heavy criticisms, including those from his one-time patron and predecessor Aquino.

In 1987, democracy movement champions in South Korea were impressed by the single-term constitution ceiling adopted in their fellow ASEAN member country, the Philippines. As a result, a provision for a four-year single term was adopted.

Hard facts

South Korean leaders have been smart enough not to digress from the popular will to serve their political expediency. Roh Tae-woo was South Korea's first democratically elected president (1988-1993). Chun Doo-hwan came to power (1980-88) after a military takeover in 1979. It was during this period that his country recorded economic growth in dazzling speed and hosted not only the 1986 Asian Games but also the 1988 Olympics.

However, Chun and Roh, both buddies since their military academy days, were convicted in 1996 for the Gwangju army massacre in which up to 2,000 youth were said to have lost their lives. Chun received death sentence and Roh was given 22 years in prison, though a year later, the duo received presidential pardon under Kim Young-sam.

What will leaders do to honour the lofty pledges they make to the voting population? Banking on God-gifted quality in governing a nation does not buy anything enduring. Politicians in many countries in the past several decades have scaled the heights of unassailable position that at first were thought to be unattainable. By the time people realise having been taken for a complete ride, their tide of disenchantment fuels frustrations at formidable levels.

Term limit or not, delivery is the first concern of most voters. More so in countries where even the most basic of needs go missing. Proven credentials are cash crops that can be converted to lasting credibility.

(Professor Kharel specialises in political communication.)

Intensify Fast Track Construction



Ballav Dahal

Mega development projects in Nepal are rarely completed on time as they face numerous hitches like a lack of necessary coordination among different relevant government agencies. A dearth of laws, clear policies and strong political will also hinder the implementation of projects. Such projects cannot advance in a smooth manner in the absence of proper planning and designing as well. In addition, the tendency of the local people to obstruct infrastructure projects on one pretext or the other is equally responsible for their snail-paced execution. Amid these impediments, major projects often reel from time and cost overrun, triggering a huge financial burden for the country.

Herculean task

Considered as a game changer in surface connectivity between Kathmandu and Nijgadh in the mid-Terai belt, the Kathmandu-Terai Fast Track Project may have a similar fate as several other national pride projects, including the Melamchi Water Supply Project and Sikta Irrigation Project. The 70.9-km road project has so far accomplished just 28.56 per cent physical progress. Looking at this insignificant achievement made during the past six and a half years, the expressway project is not likely to conclude even within its extended deadline. With the extension of its timeline, the four-lane road project is supposed to be completed by April 2027. The Nepali Army (NA) has been carrying out this important project. But the NA itself is not certain about its timely completion. Even if the NA intensifies the implementation of the project, it may be a Herculean task for it to complete the remaining 71.44 per cent work in the next three years or so.

The government decided to assign the NA to construct this expressway in the beginning of May 2017. However, the security agency began working on the project formally only after the erstwhile Ministry of Physical Planning and Works handed it over to it in the second week of August 2017. Initially, the government had targeted to finish the project by the end of December 2024. As the process of project implementation has failed to gain desired momentum since the beginning owing to various factors ranging from the COVID-19 pandemic, disruptions in the supply of explosives, delay in getting the supplementary environmental impact assessment (EIA) and the revised detailed project report (DPR) to unavailability of the required laws, the government took a decision in April this year to extend the deadline of the project by three more years until mid-April 2027. Along with this, the project's estimated cost has gone up to about Rs. 213 billion.

With continuous deferrals in inking contracts for various construction packages, the project is not going to get through within the extended timeline. And the project may undergo additional cost overrun. The project had been conceptualised more than one and a half decades back. However, it took years for the government to enter into project implementation. The government's original idea was to materialise the project under a 'build, own, operate and transfer' (BOOT) model. But the plan fell through as the government could not find a suitable development partner to execute it.

A feasibility study that was conducted in 2008 by the Asian Development Bank (ADB) had projected the cost of the project to hover around Rs. 67 billion. The project was supposed to complete within four years. In 2014, another study estimated Rs. 96.88 billion as the cost of the project. With the passage of time, the cost estimates of the project seem to have continued to increase. In 2016, India's state-funded infrastructure development and finance company, Infrastructure Leasing & Financial Services Limited (IL&FS), prepared a detailed project report on the Expressway. As per the report, the estimated project cost rose to Rs. 212 billion. Saying that the cost was very high, the government made up its mind to execute the project by mobilising its own resources. Since the NA was involved in opening tracks even in difficult terrains, the government assigned the former to take up the task of fast track construction. The government must have thought that the NA would work in a more transparent manner and conclude the project within the stipulated timeframe.

> All the development stakeholders, including the government, need to review their working styles seriously to ensure that no upcoming development projects will incur budget and time overrun.

But things could not move on efficiently because there was no good coordination among various bodies. Issues related to the acquisition of land and the felling of trees appear to have been one of the major obstacles to the implementation of the project. The project has been unable to settle the problem concerning the starting point of the fast track due to the constant opposition from the locals of Khokna. This matter must be resolved without delay to avoid possible cost and time overrun resulting from project extension. The state affairs and good governance committee under the House of Representatives has taken the slow progress of the Expressway construction seriously. The House panel has instructed the government, the NA and other pertinent agencies to play their respective roles effectively so as to accelerate the highway construction.

Lack of laws

Recently, the parliamentary committee also enquired the Chief of Army Staff Prabhu Ram Sharma about the progress of the Fast Track Project. At the meeting, Sharma bluntly said that the project could not make satisfactory progress owing to a lack of laws. "We have failed to cut down four trees from the project site for the last nine months," he said.

This situation is a clear indication that even the responsible agencies have not performed their duties dependably. However, upon its completion, this expressway will help improve road connectivity between Kathmandu and Terai. It will also reduce travel times from more than five hours to a bit more than an hour. As the government is planning to build an international airport in Nijgadh, the expressway projects holds much importance.

The government must deal with all the existing problems and challenges so as to complete the expressway construction within the deadline. Learning a lesson from the persistent delay in the execution of this and other national pride projects, all the development stakeholders, including the government, need to review their working styles seriously to ensure that no upcoming development projects will incur budget and time overrun.

(The author is a former deputy executive editor of this daily.)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

December 25, 1973

Licence For 8 New Industries

Kathmandu, Dec. 24: The Industries' Licensing Board has yesterday decided to issue license to eight different industries, reports RSS

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

TRN welcomes articles, letters and comments from our valued readers and contributors.

Please email your contributions to:

trnfeatures@hotmail.com
trnfeatures@gmail.com

Or send them to
P.O. Box 23, Kathmandu, Nepal

READER'S MAIL

Take Steps To Contain Dengue Threat

This is in reference to the news report titled "*Despite falling temperatures, dengue still a threat*" published in this daily on Dec. 24.

According to the report, mosquitoes, ticks, flies, fleas, lice and sandflies, which were previously found only in the Terai areas, are now found easily in upper hills and mountain regions.

Experts attribute this to global warming.

Climate change has enabled mosquitoes carrying dengue to areas in higher altitude where the disease was, until recently, unheard of.

This explains why hilly districts of Kathmandu and Tanahun, among others, came under the grips of dengue last year and the year before.

With so many dengue-infected people, including the children, requiring hospitalisations, this has sounded the alarm bell: the power of disease to significantly harm us in a relatively safe place cannot be underestimated. Learning from the last two years' experience, we must spring to action to defang the disease.



Taking precautionary measure is the best option available.

Prakash Gautam
Kathmandu

TAILPIECE

A blonde and a redhead met in a bar after work for a drink, and were watching the 6 O'clock news. A man was shown threatening to jump from the Brooklyn Bridge.

The blonde bet the redhead $50 that he wouldn't jump, and the redhead replied, 'I'll take that bet!'

Anyway, sure enough, he jumped, so the blonde gave the redhead the $50 she owed. The redhead said 'I can't take this, you're my friend.'

The blonde said 'No. A bet's a bet'.

So the redhead said 'Listen, I have to admit, I saw this on the 5 O'clock news, so I can't take your money'.

The blonde replied, 'Well, so did I, but I never thought he'd jump again!'

300 Indians questioned in France over trafficking fears

AFP
Paris, Dec. 24



Four French judges on Sunday began questioning more than 300 Indians travelling on a plane detained near Paris over suspicions of human trafficking.

The Nicaragua-bound Airbus A340 has been held at Vatry airport, 150 kilometres (95 miles) east of Paris, since arriving from Dubai on Thursday for refuelling after an anonymous tip-off that it was carrying potential victims of human trafficking.

The judges have the authority to extend the detention order being used by border police by eight days initially and for a another eight if required.

They have two days to complete speaking to the passengers.

"The goal is to be able to see everyone," Annick Browne, the prosecutor for the Chalons-en-Champagne region, told AFP.

The judges are being helped by translators.

The 303 passengers of the flight operated by Romanian company Legend Airlines are holed up in the airport. They include 11 unaccompanied minors, according to Paris prosecutors.

Ten of the passengers have requested asylum, a source close to the case said.

Tarpaulin covered the entrance hall's glass exterior and nearby administrative buildings, while police and gendarmes prevented access.

Two passengers in custody since Friday had their detention extended Saturday evening for up to 48 hours, according to the Paris prosecutor's office. They were being held "in order to verify" whether their role "may have been different than the others in this transport, and under what conditions and with what objectives".

Investigators have checked the identity of passengers and flight crew, and are verifying the "conditions and purposes" of their travel, the prosecutor added.

The Indian embassy in Paris said Saturday that it was working for "a rapid resolution of the situation", posting on X that "consular officials are on site".

Patrick Jaloux, the head of civil protection in the Marne region, said the passengers were understandably "frustrated" after spending three nights in the airport.

He said some of them spoke Hindi, India's national language, and the others Tamil which is spoken in southern India and in parts of Sri Lanka.

"They are in touch with their families on telephone," he said.

A source close to the inquiry told AFP that some of the Indian passengers were likely workers in the United Arab Emirates who may have sought to go to Nicaragua on their way to the United States or Canada.

Israel trains fire on south Gaza

AFP
Gaza Strip, Dec. 24



Israel said its armed forces were increasingly focused on Hamas targets in south Gaza Sunday, as the United States again pressed its ally to do more to protect Palestinian civilians.

Signalling a pivot after weeks of intensive fighting around Gaza City, the Israeli army said troops were now looking to the Hamas stronghold of Khan Yunis and elsewhere in the south.

The refugee camp-turned-city is the birthplace and powerbase of Yahya Sinwar, Hamas' leader in Gaza and the man Israel holds most responsible for the October 7 attack that sparked the war that has convulsed the region.

Hamas militants streamed across the Gaza border on October 7 and attacked southern Israeli communities, killing about 1,140 people, mostly civilians, according to an AFP tally based on Israeli figures. They also seized around 250 hostages, of whom 129 remain in Gaza.

In response, Israel vowed to crush Hamas and launched an air, land and sea offensive on Gaza. The Palestinian territory's Hamas government says the war has killed more than 20,000 people, mostly women and children.

The Israeli army said nine soldiers were killed in Gaza on Saturday, bringing to 152 its overall death toll in the territory since the ground assault began on October 27.

While the Israeli army would continue operations across Gaza, military spokesman Jonathan Conricus indicated forces were close to having operational control in north Gaza.

Now, he said, "we focus our efforts against Hamas in southern Gaza".

In central Gaza, rescuers scrambled overnight to pull people from a destroyed residential building in the city of Deir al-Balah.

"I was praying when a huge explosion occurred, and rubble fell on us. I didn't know what happened," said Yazan Moqbel, a wounded man whose sister was still under the rubble.

Israel denies directly targeting civilians and says the war against Hamas is vital to ensure October's shock raids on farms, villages and kibbutzim in Israel can never be repeated.

'We want a ceasefire'

Early on Sunday, Hamas said new strikes had hit Jabalia and Khan Yunis.

Nearly 80 percent for Gaza's 2.4 population has been displaced by the fighting, the UN estimates.

Many from the north have fled to the relative safety of the south, only to be caught up in the war for a second time.

Against this backdrop, US President Joe Biden said he had another "long talk" with Israel's hawkish Prime Minister, Benjamin Netanyahu.

Bethlehem deserted after Christmas celebrations suspended

AP
Bethlehem, Dec. 24

The normally bustling biblical birthplace of Jesus resembled a ghost town on Sunday, as Christmas Eve celebrations in Bethlehem were called off due to the Israel-Hamas war. The festive lights and Christmas tree that normally decorate Manger Square were missing, as were the throngs of foreign tourists who gather each year to mark the holiday.

Dozens of Palestinian security forces patrolled the empty square. The gift shops were slow to open on Christmas Eve, although a few did once the rain had stopped pouring down. There were few visitors, however.

"This year, without the Christmas tree and without lights, there's just darkness," said Brother John Vinh, a Franciscan monk from Vietnam who has lived in Jerusalem for six years.

He said he always comes to Bethlehem to mark Christmas, but this year was especially sobering, as he gazed at a nativity scene in Manger Square with a baby Jesus wrapped in a white shroud, reminiscent of the hundreds of children killed in the fighting in Gaza. Barbed wire surrounded the scene, the grey rubble reflecting none of the joyous lights and bursts of color that normally fill the square during the Christmas season.

"We can't justify putting out a tree and celebrating as normal, when some people (in Gaza) don't even have houses to go to," said Ala'a Salameh, one of the owners of Afteem Restaurant, a family-owned falafel restaurant just steps from the square.

Salameh said Christmas Eve is usually the busiest day of the year. "Normally, you can't find a single chair to sit, we're full from morning till midnight," said Salameh. This year, just one table was taken, by journalists taking a break from the rain.

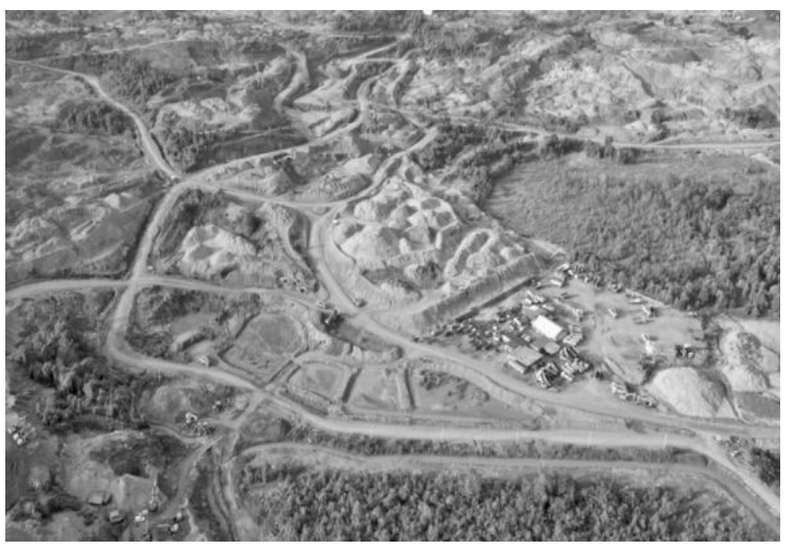
Salameh said his restaurant was operating at about 15% of normal business and wasn't able to cover operating costs. He estimated that even after the war ends, it will take another year for tourism to return to Bethlehem as normal. The cancellation of Christmas festivities is a severe blow to the town's economy. Tourism accounts for an estimated 70% of Bethlehem's income — almost all of that during the Christmas season.

With many major airlines canceling flights to Israel, few foreigners are visiting. Local officials say over 70 hotels in Bethlehem have been forced to close, leaving thousands of people unemployed.

Over 20,000 Palestinians have been killed and more than 50,000 wounded during Israel's air and ground offensive against Gaza's Hamas rulers, according to health officials there, while some 85% of the territory's 2.3 million residents have been displaced. The war was triggered by Hamas' deadly assault Oct. 7 on southern Israel in which militants killed about 1,200 people, most of them civilians, and took more than 240 hostages.

More than a dozen dead in Indonesia

AFP
Indonesia, Dec. 24



At least 13 people were killed and 38 injured in eastern Indonesia on Sunday in an explosion at a Chinese-funded nickel-processing plant, the owner of the industrial park that hosts the facility said.

The island of Sulawesi is a hub for the mineral-rich country's production of nickel, a base metal used for electric vehicle batteries and stainless steel, and Beijing's growing investment has stoked unrest over working conditions at its facilities.

The accident occurred around 5:30 am (2130 GMT Saturday) at a plant owned by PT Indonesia Tsingshan Stainless Steel (ITSS) in the Morowali Industrial Park in Central Sulawesi province, a spokesperson for the complex said in a statement.

"(The death toll) increased by one person, from 12 to 13," he told AFP, also revising the number of injured down one to 38.

He identified the dead as eight Indonesians and five Chinese workers.

An initial investigation showed the explosion happened during repair work on a furnace when a flammable liquid ignited and the subsequent blast caused nearby oxygen tanks to explode as well, the official said.

The fire was extinguished Sunday morning, according to the statement.

Tsingshan Holding Group, the world's biggest nickel producer and China's biggest stainless steelmaker, holds a majority stake in ITSS.

ITSS is a tenant in the industrial park, which is also majority owned by Tsingshan along with local partner Bintang Delapan.

The firm that runs the industrial park said it was "deeply saddened by this disaster, particularly for the families affected".

It said the remains of several identified victims had been flown home.

Footage shared with AFP showed plumes of smoke emerging from the facility with emergency services at the scene and workers looking on.

A photo shared with AFP showed the bodies of the victims lined up on top of orange body bags in a room in one of the clinics at the industrial complex.

"Their faces were burnt, their clothes were all burnt," a worker at the industrial complex told AFP on condition of anonymity.

Acting Morowali district head Rachmansyah Ismail told broadcaster Kompas TV that as of Sunday afternoon 25 of the injured -- 15 Indonesians and 10 foreign nationals -- had been immediately rushed to hospital after the blast. Seventeen were seriously injured while eight suffered moderate injuries, he said.

In January, two workers including a Chinese national were killed at a nickel smelting plant in the same industrial park after a riot broke out during a protest over safety conditions and pay.

Deadly fires are not uncommon in Indonesia, a sprawling country of more than 250 million people where safety regulations are often flouted.

In June a fire at the same plant left one dead and six others injured, in another incident that has stoked concern over safety at facilities funded and operated by Chinese companies.

The facility where the riot and fire took place is operated by PT Gunbuster Nickel Industry (GNI), a local unit of China's Jiangsu Delong Nickel Industry.

PRISM

Police find hand grenade was a poop bag dispenser

Oregon: Police in Oregon said an object that appeared to be a hand grenade turned out to be a dispenser for dog poop bags.

The McMinnville Police Department said in a Facebook post that the "item of concern" was spotted near the running track at Patton Middle School, away from school buildings.

Students were kept inside the school while police consulted with the Oregon State Police Bomb Squad personnel. The department used a drone to get close-up photos of the apparent hand grenade while keeping a safe distance from the suspected explosive.

"After reviewing the photographs, the item was determined to be a dog waste bag dispenser that is manufactured to resemble a hand grenade," the post said.

Christmas tree maze on island

Jersey : A Christmas tree maze on the island of Jersey might be a new world record after being constructed from more than 800 recycled trees.

Bino Rodrigues, organizer of the Jersey Christmas Tree Experience at Howard Davis Park, said he found out the world record for the largest display of illuminated Christmas trees was set at 797 trees in the United States in 2019 and he realized his attraction had nearly as many trees.

Rodrigues reached out to businesses that export Christmas trees and took their leftover stock to push his maze over 800 trees.

(AP)

Astronaut will be invited on NASA moon landing

AP
Cape Canaveral, Fla., Dec. 24



PHOTO: AP

Artemis II crew members from left, Reid Wiseman, Victor Glover, Christina Hammock Koch, and Jeremy Hansen speak to members of the media outside the West Wing of the White House in Washington, Thursday, Dec. 14, 2023, after meeting with President Joe Biden.

An international astronaut will join U.S. astronauts on the moon by decade's end under an agreement announced Wednesday by NASA and the White House. The news came as Vice President Kamala Harris convened a meeting in Washington of the National Space Council, the third such gathering under the Biden administration.

There was no mention of who the international moonwalker might be or even what country would be represented. A NASA spokeswoman later said that crews would be assigned closer to the lunar-landing missions, and that no commitments had yet been made to another country.

NASA has included international astronauts on trips to space for decades. Canadian Jeremy Hansen will fly around the moon a year or so from now with three U.S. astronauts.

Another crew would actually land; it would be the first lunar touchdown by astronauts in more than a half-century. That's not likely to occur before 2027, according to the U.S. Government Accountability Office.

All 12 moonwalkers during NASA's Apollo program of the 1960s and 1970s were U.S. citizens. The space agency's new moon exploration program is named Artemis after Apollo's mythological twin sister. Including international partners "is not only sincerely appreciated, but it is urgently needed in the world today," Hansen told the council.

NASA has long stressed the need for global cooperation in space, establishing the Artemis Accords along with the U.S. State Department in 2020 to promote responsible behavior not just at the moon but everywhere in space. Representatives from all 33 countries that have signed the accords so far were expected at the space council's meeting in Washington.

"We know from experience that collaboration on space delivers," said Secretary of State Antony Blinken, citing the Webb Space Telescope, a U.S., European and Canadian effort.

Notably missing from the Artemis Accords: Russia and China, the only countries besides the U.S. to launch their own citizens into orbit. Russia is a partner with NASA in the International Space Station, along with Europe, Japan and Canada. Even earlier in the 1990s, the Russian and U.S. space agencies teamed up during the shuttle program to launch each other's astronauts to Russia's former orbiting Mir station.

During Wednesday's meeting, Harris also announced new policies to ensure the safe use of space as more and more private companies and countries aim skyward. Among the issues that the U.S. is looking to resolve: the climate crisis and the growing amount of space junk around Earth. A 2021 anti-satellite missile test by Russia added more than 1,500 pieces of potentially dangerous orbiting debris, and Blinken joined others at the meeting in calling for all nations to end such destructive testing.

TODAY IN HISTORY

1000 – The foundation of the Kingdom of Hungary: Hungary is established as a Christian kingdom by Stephen I of Hungary.

1766 – Mapuches in Chile launch a series of surprise attacks against the Spanish starting the Mapuche uprising of 1766.

1946 – The first European self-sustaining nuclear chain reaction is initiated within the Soviet Union's F-1 nuclear reactor.[35]

1951 – A bomb explodes at the home of Harry T. Moore and Harriette V. S. Moore, early leaders of the Civil Rights Movement, killing Harry instantly and fatally wounding Harriette.

1968 – Apollo program: Apollo 8 performs the first successful Trans-Earth injection (TEI) maneuver, sending the crew and spacecraft on a trajectory back to Earth from Lunar orbit.

2019 – Twenty people are killed and thousands are left homeless by Typhoon Phanfone in the Philippines.



PHOTO: SUJAN GURUNG/TRN

Nepali Congress President Sher Bahadur Deuba attending a programme held to commemorate birth centenary of late prime minister Krishna Prasad Bhattarai held at the party's headquarters in Sanepa, Lalitpur on Sunday.

Deuba lauds late Bhattarai's contributions

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 24

Nepali Congress President Sher Bahadur Deuba has said that the country will not backtrack from the current Federal Democratic Republic system.

Speaking at a discussion progamme organised at the NC Central Office, Sanepa of Lalitpur, on Sunday to mark the 100th birth anniversary of the former NC president and Prime Minister Krishna Prasad Bhattarai, Deuba said although some voices were being raised against the republican system, they would not weaken the system and there was no possibility of change in the current political system.

Deuba said if the NC moved ahead on the path shown by the late Bhattarai, it would not have to look behind.

"Now matters are being propped up with the intention of weakening the republic system that we have achieved from our long struggle. We should move forward defeating such matters. We cannot return to history, it will be better to move forward by strengthening democracy," he said.

Deuba recalled the late Bhattarai as a selfless and self-sacrificing leader.

Deuba recalled his meeting with Bhattarai in Nakkhu jail first time and found with full sense of honour.

"Bhattarai never seemed worried, was unselfish and established him as an altruistic personality," Deuba said remembering the then political leaders who were in jail for advocating democracy in the country.

Deuba also acknowledged Bhattarai's contributions to issue the 1990 constitution that was owned by the then monarch as well as the citizens.

He also committed to preparing a document on the late Bhattarai.

NC Vice President and Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Defense Purna Bahadur Khadka also remembered Bhattarai as a leader with dedication, integrity and unselfishness.

DPM Khadka said Bhattarai had had no animosity with anyone and did not accuse anyone when he lost the election while serving as the party President and prevented the party from a possible split.

"Bhattarai had a high dedication to the nation and people," Khadka said.

NC Vice President and Minister for Law, Justice and Parliamentary Affairs Dhanraj Gurung said Bhattarai was a leader who had integrity and simplicity.

CHRISTMAS TODAY

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 24

The Christian community in Nepal is celebrating Christmas with fanfare throughout the county on Monday.

The day is celebrated every year on December 25 to commemorate the birth of Jesus Christ. The king of Rome Constantine started the celebration in 350 AD.

Non-Christians have also started celebrating the festival with a lot of zeal after Nepal was declared a secular state in 2007. Since then Christmas has been celebrated as one of the national festivals in Nepal.

With the start of December, decorated Christmas trees started appearing in big shopping malls in the three cities of the Kathmandu Valley.

To mark the day, Christians visit churches and sing carols song, perform dances, exchange gifts and eat different delicious food items.

Christmas is the festival of light and snow. Christians celebrate the day by decorating Christmas trees colourfully and giving gifts.

The Christmas feasts comprises fish, roasted chicken, vegetables and other Nepali food along with Christmas pudding, pumpkin pies and others.

On the occasion, the government has announced a public holiday.

France's undocumented migrants face uncertain future

AFP
Paris, Dec. 24

Despite facing serious labour shortages, the French government passed a more restrictive immigration bill this week after watering down measures that would have streamlined the legalisation of foreign workers. But some of the law's new provisions may still offer a glimmer of hope for the country's hundreds of thousands of undocumented migrants.

Until it became unstuck, the sticking point – as far as France's right wing was concerned – for the Macron government's sweeping immigration bill was how to deal with the country's undocumented migrants.

In presenting the bill's initial text a year ago, Interior Minister Gérald Darmanin and Labour Minister Olivier Dussopt included provisions making it easier to legalise undocumented migrants working in sectors with labour shortages. But representatives from Marine Le Pen's far-right National Rally party repeatedly stated they would not endorse legislation granting undocumented workers legal status.

After the language of the bill was significantly weakened in a joint committee, Le Pen saw an opening for a strategic victory and changed course; it passed the National Assembly (lower house) on Tuesday with Le Pen's endorsement.

While it does not go as far as the original text, the new law gives undocumented workers in high-demand occupations a path to obtaining residency permits. Speaking a day after the law was passed, Darmanin said he expects the number of legalisations (régularisations) to double, with "ten thousand additional foreign workers each year".

At the same time, the law will make it more difficult – and more risky – for undocumented workers in France: a law abolished by former president François Hollande that allowed police to fine foreigners up to €3,750 if they are found to be in the country unlawfully has been reintroduced. The bill also steps up sanctions against companies employing illegal workers.

The number of undocumented workers, or what the French call the "sans papiers" (without papers), is impossible to calculate. Darmanin himself estimates the number to be between 600,000 and 900,000. Amadou* moved to France from Mali on a work visa in 2001 (overstaying a legal visa is the most common path to becoming an undocumented migrant in Europe).

Finding work has never been a problem. He has primarily worked in the hospitality sector and in retirement homes – he currently works at a restaurant in Paris's 7th arrondissement (district). "I've been working in France for 19 years without a holiday, without any sick days or absences," he says.

Amadou first applied for working papers – to no avail – in 2012. The second time he applied, in 2018, he was denied because he didn't have children or a partner to support. Since then, despite help from his employer, he has been unable to get another meeting.

Amadou belongs to an association that supports undocumented migrants in Montreuil, a suburb just east of Paris. He often participates in protests but realises he and people like him are largely powerless. "I'd like to get my papers but, considering it's [the politicians] who decide, we are not their priority," he says.

France's right-wing Les Republicains party and the far-right National Rally are reluctant to endorse a path towards legalisation because they believe migrants choose France for its advantageous social system. Therefore, the logic goes, making life difficult for migrants will prevent more migrants from coming – an idea that has no grounding in research.

By contrast, studies have found that legalising migrants has positive macroeconomic and fiscal outcomes in developed countries.

Nepali saved from death row in Qatar

BY LILA RAJ KHADKA
Birtamod, Dec. 24

Locals of Tribeni Tole in Kankai Municipality-4, Jhapa have successfully brought back Subash Raut, 33, a resident of the same locality, who was convicted of murdering his friend and sentenced to death by the Qatar government.

Three years ago, Raut was sentenced to death for killing his roommate Lama Kaji Rai of Aiselukharka in Khotang. Raut informed that Rai died in a fight that broke out when friends working in different companies had arrived in his room. After the incident, the Qatari police charged Raut with the murder and sentenced him to death. However, Raut has consistently claimed his innocence in the matter.

Meanwhile, Raut's family including two children, a wife, mother and father in Nepal faced great distress after the news. His mother Durga Maya also passed away upon hearing the news.

To return Raut to Nepal, a committee was formed under the coordination of former ward chair Govinda Paudel. The committee raised Rs. 2,024,000 from Nepalis living home and abroad to pay the 'blood money' eventually leading to Raut's return home after three years.

Raut was welcomed by local-level representatives and locals on Sunday. Upon his arrival, Raut said that he would never go abroad again and decided to stay and work in Nepal. He shared his constant stress while in jail about leaving his children orphaned as he had no assets other than a small piece of ancestral land and a house.



PHOTO: LILA RAJ KHADKA/TRN

Subash Raut, a convicted of murdering friend and sentenced to death by Qatar government, being welcomed in his home town after his arrival on Sunday.

Media should...

Earlier, speaking at a press meet organised in Biratnagar by the Press Centre Nepal Morang, Minister Sharma said that the development of information technology should be made a medium to earn foreign currency.

Stating that there had been an increase in the possibility of earning foreign by exporting information technology (IT), she said that the government was working to develop the IT sector as a new employment opportunity.

Minister Sharma said that the government was preparing to hold an IT exhibition to explore more possibilities in the IT field. She said since laws could not be amended in time, some problems were seen in the IT sector because there had been extensive transformation in the IT sector in the past 10 years.

Claiming that there was no possibility of change in the government leadership for now, Minister Sharma said that the current government would initiate new ways after completing the first year in office.

Loan shark victims get...

The government had formed the Commission in April and introduced the ordinance after loan shark victims protested in Kathmandu for several days demanding justice. The Parliament in July passed a new bill criminalising loan sharking.

Narayan Prasad Bhattarai, Joint Secretary and Spokesperson for the Ministry of Home Affairs said that they would implement the report received from the Commission.

Hundreds of cases to be settled

Meanwhile, our District Correspondent Bom Lal Giri from Nawalparasi East stated that 21 complaints were filed in the district administration office during the period.

Of the 21 complaints, four were settled in compromise. However, the victim complained that the agreement was not implemented. On the contrary, those who are called perpetrators have gone to court against the victims and the struggle committee. Maya Bhandari, one of the said loan sharks, has filed a case against Goma Ghimire, the former president of the Struggle Committee, and Hemraj Dahal, the current president of the Loan Sharking Struggle Committee, for defaming her.

According to Yadav Parajuli, head of the litigation branch of the district administration office, seven cases are pending in the district court. Because the perpetrators are strong in evidence, there is no situation for the victims to go to court. Chief District Officer Kalpana Shrestha said that due to a lack of sufficient evidence, the alleged perpetrators could not be arrested as per the complaints registered.

Likewise, in Bara, under the unfair transaction, the district administration office has settled 654 cases out of 3,322 total cases and succeeded in returning Rs. 126 million to the victims. According to our district correspondent Shiva Shanker Mishra, in the district, the commission members have succeeded in returning 20 Bigaha, 16 kattha and 10 dhur land of the victims in their registration. Non-gazetted officer Sanoj Kumar Mahoto of the litigation branch of the DAO said that 1736 cases are yet to be settled and 1,586 cases are under the process of settlement through discussions.

Yemen warring parties agree to ceasefire, UN-led peace process

AFP
Dubai, Dec. 24

Yemen's warring parties have committed to a new ceasefire and agreed to engage in a UN-led peace process to end the war, the UN envoy for Yemen said Saturday.

The announcement by UN special envoy for Yemen, Hans Grundberg, marks the latest step to end the nine-year war that has killed hundreds of thousands of people and triggered one of the world's worst humanitarian crises.

It follows recent meetings by Grundberg in Saudi Arabia and Oman with Rashad Al-Alimi, head of Yemen's Saudi-backed presidential council and Mohammed Abdul Salam, the chief negotiator of the Iran-backed Huthi rebels.

Grundberg said he "welcomes the parties' commitment to a set of measures to implement a nation-wide ceasefire... and (to) engage in preparations for the resumption of an inclusive political process", according to a statement by his office.

The envoy "will now engage with the parties to establish a road map under UN auspices that includes these commitments and supports their implementation", the statement added.

Yemen has been gripped by conflict since the Iran-backed Huthi rebels took control of the capital Sanaa in 2014, triggering a Saudi-led military intervention in support of the beleaguered government the following year.

A UN-brokered ceasefire that took effect in April 2022 brought a sharp reduction in hostilities. The truce expired in October last year, though fighting largely remains on hold.

Grundberg will now "engage with the parties to establish a roadmap under UN auspices" to end the war. The road map also includes commitments to pay civil servants' salaries, open routes into the rebel-blockaded city of Taez and other parts of Yemen and resume oil exports, according to the statement.

"Yemenis are watching and waiting for this new opportunity to provide for tangible results and progress towards lasting peace," Grundberg said.

"The parties have taken a significant step. Their commitments are, first and foremost, an obligation to the Yemeni people."

The agreement comes amid a flurry of attacks by the Huthi rebels on key shipping lanes in the Red Sea in solidarity with Palestinians in the Gaza Strip, where Israel is fighting Hamas militants. The Huthis have pledged to attack Israel-linked vessels or ships heading to Israeli ports unless an end is brought to the Israel-Hamas war that started on October 7.

They have launched more than 100 drone and missile attacks, targeting 10 merchant vessels involving more than 35 different countries, according to the Pentagon.

The attacks by the rebels are imperilling a transit route that carries up to 12 percent of global trade, prompting the United States to set up a multinational naval task force to protect Red Sea shipping.

The Huthi "military actions hinder progress towards a peaceful resolution", Mohammed Albasha, a senior Middle East analyst for the US-based Navanti Group, told AFP.

"The Huthis have transitioned... to becoming aggressors targeting civilian assets," he said. The latest agreement also coincides with a push by Saudi Arabia to extricate itself from the conflict, despite slim hopes of a lasting peace.

The oil-rich monarchy gave a signal this year by resuming ties with Iran, which backs the Huthis against the Saudi-supported government in a proxy war.

The Saudi-led intervention's stated aim was to protect civilians from Huthi attacks, restore the government and stop Yemen becoming a safe haven for Iranian-backed forces.

Eight years in, the rebels control swathes of the country and command an impressive arsenal of weapons that they have used to attack Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates, another coalition member.

Wildlife menace common near...

According to Dr. Pant, over 300,000 tourists visit the park annually, and managing their movement is also a priority.

The park, situated north of the Kathmandu Valley, covers parts of Kathmandu, Nuwakot, Sindhupalchowk, and Dhading districts, with an elevation ranging from 960 to 2732 metres above sea level.

Declared the country's ninth national park in 2002, it was previously managed as the Shivapuri Watershed and Wildlife Reserve under the Shivapuri Watershed Development Board. It covers an area of 159 sq. km.

The park boasts a rich biodiversity, hosting 1,114 flowering plants, 131 pteridophytes, 65 mammal species, 348 birds, 124 butterflies, 11 amphibians, 20 reptile species, and two species of fish.

Emerging artist Humagain's 'Nirbichar Bichar' on display

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 24

An art exhibition titled Nirbichar Bichar (The Idea of Having No Idea) is currently on display at Bikalpa Art Centre in Pulchok, Lalitpur.

The solo art exhibition by emerging artist Binaya Humagain showcases a mesmerising collection of paintings that delve into the realms of contemplation and reflection.

The paintings in the collection were created as a method of meditation during a challenging period in the artist's life.

The collection portrays his meditative process through a blend of lines, drawings, paintings, and pyrography, ranging from miniature to colossal canvases, depicting his spiritual and mental journey.

Humangain's strokes and vibrant palette come together to create a visual symphony that invites viewers to explore the depths of the paradoxical nature of creativity and the simultaneous presence and absence of a definite concept in art and life.

'Nirbichar Bichar' transcends traditional artistic boundaries, offering a unique and thought-provoking experience for art lovers of all backgrounds.

Through each art piece, the artist asks viewers to delve into the realm of the unknown with him, embracing uncertainty and the chaos that often precedes the birth of a concept.

A recent graduate from Tribhuvan University, Binaya is known for his ability to infuse his emotions into every brushstroke, expressing a profound connection to the theme of contemplation in 'Nirbichar Bichar' .

The exhibition, which began on December 21, will continue until January 18.





11th Bhedetar Food Festival from December 31

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Dharan, Dec. 24

Hotel Association Bhedetar is gearing up for a three-day food festival, scheduled to commence on December 31 with the slogan, 'Bhedetar is a jewel of nature, our desire to attract tourists'.

During a press meeting on Saturday, Tumraj Limbu, the President of the Hotel Association, said that the 11th Bhedetar Food Festival would showcase a diverse array of organic and local ethnic foods.

Limbu emphasised the Association's commitment to identifying and promoting religious and tourist destinations, fostering an environment conducive to increased visitation.

Bhedetar is one of the major tourist spots in Koshi Province.

is situated in the Bhedetar Koshi Province, encompassing Some parts of Bhedetar lie in Dharan Sub-Metropolitan City, Sunsari, and other parts in Ward No. 6 of Sangurigarhi Rural Municipality, Dhankuta.

Koshi is also a famous tourist destination preferred by domestic and foreign tourists.

Ranging from 1,420 to 1,750 metres above sea level, Bhedetar stands out as a picturesque location in the Koshi region.

Chairman Limbu highlighted Bhedetar's recent inclusion in the Sangurigadhi Rural Municipality, transforming it into a spatial structure.

Jitendra Rumdali, the former president of the association, said that



Bhedetar's beauty, describing it as an appealing destination for one to two days' stay, particularly renowned among the eastern hill districts.

Notably, Bhedetar's comfortable summer climate attracts tourists, especially from the Tarai area of Nepal and neighbouring India, seeking relief from the heat.

The weather in Bhedetar is such that, in a short while, shade will envelop this place, and soon after, the clouds are expected to dissipate, said Rumdali.

According to the organiser, this location, renowned for receiving the second-highest amount of rainfall after Pokhara, gained international fame when CNN's survey ranked Namche Bazaar of Bhedetar as the fifth must-visit destination among the top 12 in the world.

The upcoming food festival promises a myriad of attractions, including an agricultural exhibition, ethnic culinary delights, handmade domestic products, a flower nursery, traditional cultural displays, and various adventure sports and tourism activities such as zip lining, sky bridges, and mountain biking, informed the organiser.

Local and national artists will also perform cultural programmes, enhancing the overall experience for festival attendees, said the organiser.

Actor Ryan O'Neal died of congestive heart failure

AGENCIES
Los Angeles, Dec. 24



Actor Ryan O'Neal's cause of death has been officially revealed, two weeks after the actor died on December 8.

The 'Love Story' actor died at the age of 82, reports 'Mirror.co.uk'. His death was announced by his son Patrick O'Neal, 56, who shared the sad news in a post on Instagram.

Patrick wrote, "So this is the toughest thing I've ever had to say but here we go. My dad passed away peacefully today, with his loving team by his side supporting him and loving him as he would us."

At first, Ryan's cause of death was unknown, but now it has emerged that he died of congestive heart failure. Ryan's death certificate was obtained by the Blast on Friday, revealing that the congestive heart failure was a result of suffering from cardiomyopathy for years.

As per 'Mirror.co.uk', when Ryan died, he was hospitalised at Providence Saint John's Health Center in Santa Monica, California. The death certificate lists no other contributing factors to Ryan's death. According to the NHS, congestive heart failure is a term that is rarely used today, with it instead referred to as just heart failure.

The condition means that the heart is unable to pump blood around the body properly. "It usually happens because the heart has become too weak or stiff", according to the site.

Following Ryan's death being announced by his son Patrick on social media, his daughter - whom he had worked with on several occasions - Tatum O'Neal, 60, also spoke out.

Addressing his death, Tatum told People in a statement, "I feel great sorrow with my father's passing. He meant the world to me".

Tatum added that she "loved him very much" and that she knew her father felt the same about her. "I'll miss him forever and I feel very lucky that we ended on such good terms", she added.

'Extended Family' inspired by real-life relationship of Celtics owner, wife and her ex

AP
Boston, Dec. 24



When Boston Celtics owner Wyc Grousbeck felt like his life could be the premise for a television sitcom, he knew just where to turn: His friend Tom Werner, a Red Sox owner and TV veteran who was behind megahits like "The Cosby Show," "Roseanne" and "That '70s Show."

The result is "Extended Family," which premieres on NBC on Saturday night starring Jon Cryer Donald Faison and Abigail Spencer in a love triangle inspired by the real-life dynamic that developed between Grousbeck, his new wife and her ex-husband — a lifelong Celtics fan.

"He looked at her like: 'There's a million guys in New England you could be dating,'" said Werner, who advised the three on developing the show and joined them as an executive producer. "What am I going to tell my friends?"

The ensuing hijinks play off the decision by Emilia Fazzalari and George Geyer to follow their divorce with an arrangement called nesting: Instead of making the children bounce around during custody swaps, the kids stay in the family apartment and the parents move in and out.

"The nest is someplace where Julia and I have tried to give our kids the false impression that nothing has changed," Jim Kearney (Cryer) says in the pilot, which revolves around a true story in which Geyer was left in charge of his daughter's goldfish "Googles" while she was at summer camp. The fish dies, they decide to replace it with a look-alike, and then wackiness ensues. Fazzalari and Geyer said the unusually amicable divorce was an attempt to minimize the disruption for their two children.

"We decided to get divorced, and we decided that we should pay the price for that, not the kids," Geyer said in a recent interview. "You can choose two routes when you get divorced. You can choose to be horrible or you can make the best of it. And we chose to make the best of it."

And everything was fine — until Fazzalari started dating Grousbeck.

In the pilot, Jim hits Celtics owner Trey Turner (Faison) up for tickets and his ex-wife Julia Mariano (Spencer) says: "Looks like we both met the man of our dreams." But in real life there were more mixed emotions for Geyer, who grew up outside of Boston, went to Boston College and raised his kids as Boston sports fans while living in New York.

"It has to sting, right?" he said. "I'm a Celtics fan and she starts dating the owner of the Celtics? Not to mention being Irish and growing up in Boston and having all my Boston friends — you know how they like to give people a hard time. You can imagine the grief I've taken from them as far as my wife being now married to the owner of the Boston Celtics."

On a recent Zoom call, Grousbeck, Fazzalari and Geyer banter good-naturedly, just as the characters do. When Geyer refers to Fazzalari as his wife, she corrects him: "ex-wife"; Geyer gives Grousbeck a hard time about the trade of NBA championship-winning point guard Rajon Rondo.

"It's not a documentary," Geyer said. "But if you watch the way the three characters interact on screen, it is pretty similar."

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

ARIES: A softer touch is the way to handle things. Easy-going Venus in your 8th House of Sensuality is trining Neptune in your 12th House of Surrender, and while the 8th house is normally a very extreme territory.

TAURUS: People can bring joy into your life from every angle. The lovely collaboration between your sign's ruler Venus in your partnership sector and Neptune in your friendship sector.

GEMINI: Your usual responsibilities might begin to feel wonderfully easy. Loving Venus is moving along through your efficient 6th house, mitigating many work issues.

CANCER: Your creativity is practically boundless. A wonderful trine between Venus in your joyful 5th house and Neptune in your expansive 9th house will provide you with endless inspiration.

LEO: Knowing people have your back is extra reassuring at present. You'll be reminded of the support available to you as Venus in your emotional 4th house trines Neptune in your transformative 8th house.

VIRGO: There's rarely been a better time to circulate and socialize. Venus in your communication sector is collaborating for a rare trine with Neptune in your partnership sector, which could inspire you to reach out.

LIBRA: Work probably won't feel like work to you today. Everything is flowing smoothly, thanks to a gentle trine between Venus in your income sector and Neptune in your responsible 6th house.

SCORPIO: You can shine more brightly than anyone at this time. Venus in your dramatic sign is lighting you up from within. You're almost glowing as it trines Neptune in your shimmering 5th house.

SAGITTARIUS: It's a wonderful day to let go and go with the flow. Pleasing Venus is swimming through your dreamy 12th house, encouraging you to don your rose-colored glasses!

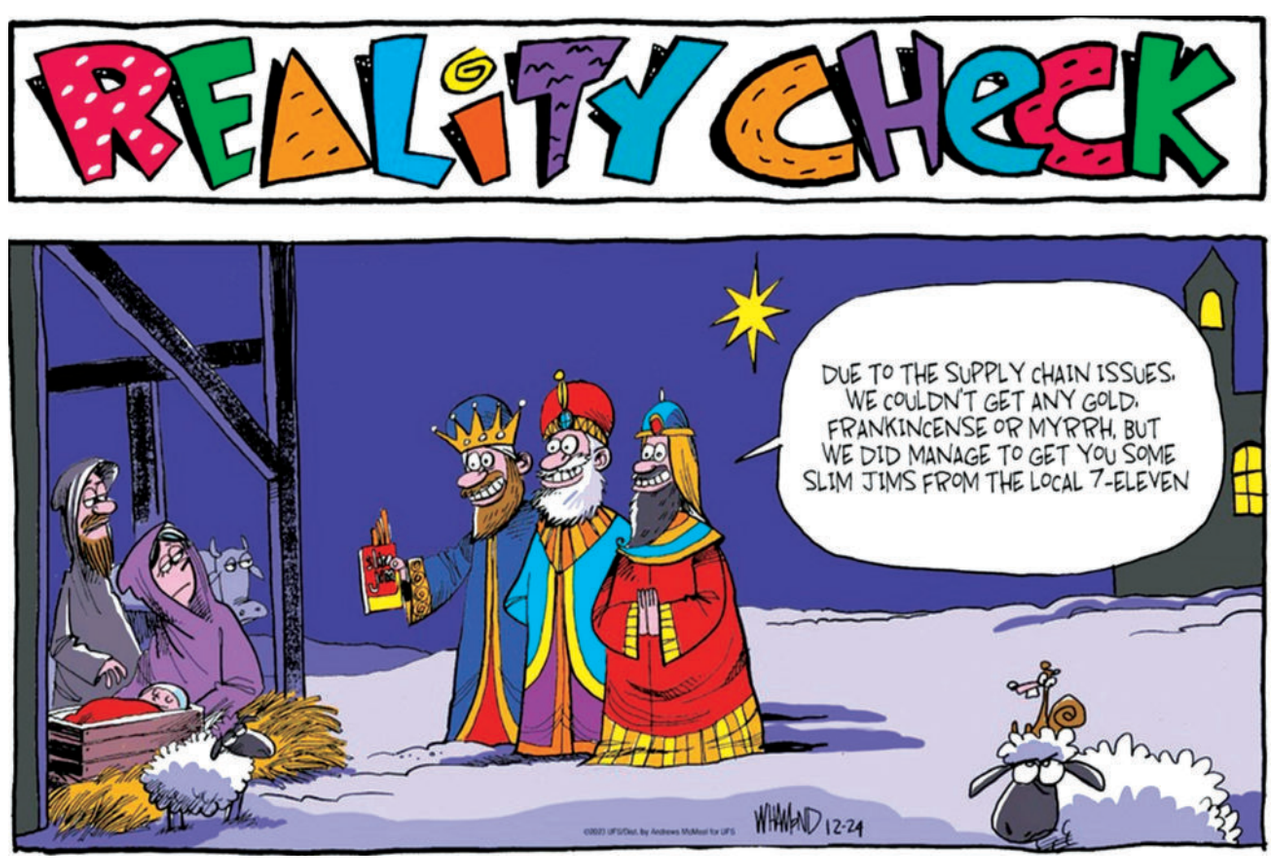
CAPRICORN: Right now, it may only take a single kind word to make someone else's day ten times better. A special trine between loving Venus in your connected 11th house and gentle Neptune in your 3rd House.

AQUARIUS: You can skate all the way to the finish line today. There is a wonderful trine between Venus in your 10th House of Career and Neptune in your 2nd House of Finances.

PISCES: The world is wonderfully limitless all of a sudden! Darling Venus in your 9th House of Foreign Cultures is designing a collab with magical Neptune in your inspired sign.

CARTOON

gocomics.com



Arsenal hold Liverpool to seal top spot at Christmas

AFP
London, Dec. 24

Arsenal will spend Christmas Day on top of the Premier League after they held title rivals Liverpool to a pulsating 1-1 draw at Anfield on Saturday, while Manchester United crashed to a dismal 2-0 defeat at West Ham that piled pressure on Erik ten Hag.

Mikel Arteta's Arsenal took an early lead through Gabriel Magalhaes, but Mohamed Salah hauled Liverpool level before the interval.

A draw was arguably the right result after both sides flexed their muscles to show why they have emerged as the leading contenders to win the title.

Chasing a first title since 2004, Arsenal sit one point clear of second placed Liverpool heading into the festive period.

The team that has topped the Premier League at Christmas has gone on to win the title in six of the past 10 seasons, but the draw on Merseyside was also a boost to the chasing pack.

Third placed Aston Villa are level on points with Liverpool, fourth placed Tottenham are three points further back, while champions Manchester City are six points adrift of the leaders with a game in hand.

"An unbelievable game of football, one of the most intense I've witnessed in 20 years in this league. For many moments we were on top, in the last 20 minutes we wanted it more, but a draw is a fair result," Arteta said.

At the London Stadium, Ten Hag's United side were blown away by late West Ham strikes from Jarrod Bowen and Mohammed Kudus, condemning the visitors to an eighth Premier League loss already this season.

United, languishing in eighth place, have managed just one win in their last seven games in all competitions.

They have lost three of their last four matches and failed to score in any of them for the first time since 1992.

It has been a wretched second season for Ten Hag, whose team have been eliminated from Europe after finishing bottom of their Champions League group, while also crashing out of the League Cup.

United have lost 13 games in all competitions this season -- their most defeats before Christmas since 1930-31 when they finished bottom of the table.

Welch makes history

At Craven Cottage, Rebecca Welch became the first woman to referee a Premier League match as struggling Burnley won 2-0 at Fulham.

Last month, the 40-year-old became the first woman to act as fourth official in a Premier League game as part of the officiating team for Fulham's match against Manchester United.

It was an impressive debut for Welch, who ignored boos from the Fulham fans when she booked Calvin Bassey after his arm caught Josh Brownhill.

Wilson Odobert's 47th minute opener for Burnley needed no intervention from Welch and her assistants, with Sander Berge's 66th minute goal sealing just the third win this season for the second-bottom Clarets.

Tottenham moved up to fourth, three points behind Arsenal, with a 2-1 win against Everton in north London.

Richarlison put Tottenham ahead against his former club in the ninth minute.

Son Heung-min doubled the lead in the 18th minute and Andre Gomes's 82nd minute reply was too late for Everton.

Luton bolstered their bid for survival with an impressive 1-0 win against Newcastle at Kenilworth Road.

Bournemouth's Dominic Solanke ruined Nuno Espirito Santo's first match in charge of Nottingham Forest as the striker's hat-trick sealed a 3-2 victory.



National players deliver in PM Cup

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 24

National cricket team players participating in the PM Cup Women's National Cricket Tournament 2080 were in the front to lead their respective teams to a win.

Koshi Province, Armed Police Force Club (APF), Sudurpashchim and Bagmati won against Madhes, Lumbini, Karnali and Gandaki respectively on the third match day of the tournament.

Koshi won the match against Madhes by 60 runs. Madhes could only score 69/9 at the end of 20 overs while chasing a target of 130, which Koshi posted with the loss of four wickets.

Two national players – Rubina Chhetry and Begam Apsari – were the highest scorers for Koshi. Rubina crossed the half-century mark and scored 57 out of 64 balls. Apsari scored 39 in 41 balls.

Sabnam Rai, a right-arm off-break bowler for the national team, helped with the bowling as she took two wickets and gave off only eight runs. She was supported by Alisha Kadaiya, who took two wickets giving only seven runs.

Indu Barma and Mamta Chaudhary, two players who have represented Nepal on the international stage, both crossed the half-century mark for APF as it posted a target of 152 in the loss of three wickets. Indu remained not out at 70 off 51 balls while Chaudhary was sent back to the pavilion after scoring 59 off 58 balls.

Indu was also great with the ball as she took three wickets by giving seven runs to help APF restrict Lumbini to 61/9 after the end of 20 overs of the chase.

Sudurpashchim also posted the same target as APF, but against Karnali. In the loss of four wickets, national player Kabita Joshi's knock of 78 runs off 50 balls helped Sudurpashchim reach 151 at the end of its innings. It was the highest score of the day. Sudurpashchim was also good with the bowling as Karnali could only score 70 at the end of 20 overs by losing nine wickets.

Experienced Yashoda Bist, who bats with her right hand, took the helm to earn the win for Bagmati against Gandaki. Staying not out, Bist hit a knock of 39 runs from 41 balls to chase the target of 113. Bagmati won the match with four wickets after scoring 116 in 18.4 overs.

Sony Pakhrin, a national player, was the second-highest scorer for Bagmati as she scored 17 off 26 balls.

Of the seven league-stage matches, the eight teams have played three matches each. APF and Koshi are unbeaten in the first three matches and are in the top two positions in the league table respectively.

The two top teams will be facing each other on Monday. Karnali (8th position), Gandaki (5th position) and Bagmati (4th position) will also be facing Lumbini (6th position), Madhes (7th position) and Sudurpashchim (3rd position) on December 25 respectively.



PHOTO:BIKAS/TRN
Players of Koshi Province (left) reacts after taking the wicket of Madhes Province during the PM Cup Women's National T20 Cricket Tournament at TU Cricket Ground, Kirtipur, Sunday.

> Koshi Province, Armed Police Force Club (APF), Sudurpashchim and Bagmati won against Madhes, Lumbini, Karnali and Gandaki respectively on the third match day of the tournament.

NATIONAL SWIMMING ON WEDNESDAY

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 24

The Nepal Swimming Association (NSA) has announced that it will be organizing a national swimming competition in the winter season for the first time. The 26th edition of the NSA Cup national swimming championship will take place on Wednesday and Thursday.

This will be the first national championship to be held in cold weather since the construction of an air-conditioned swimming pool at the International Sports Complex in Lalitpur. The competition will have a total of 51 age groups and open categories, which will be organized jointly by the NSA and Bagmati Province Sports Development Council.

Approximately 150 players will participate in the championship in different age groups. A championship trophy will be awarded to the top 3 teams with the best scores in each age group. NSA President Ashok Bajracharya mentioned that this event will be a great opportunity for Nepali swimmers to showcase their talents and compete with each other safely and fairly. "The construction of an air-conditioned swimming pool will enable training and competitions to be held in Nepal in any weather condition, which will ultimately benefit Nepali athletes in the future", said Bajracharya.

Nepal dominate South Asian Skateboard

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 24

Nepali skateboarders dominated the 5th South Asian Skateboard Competition, which was organised by Nepal Skating and Skateboarding Association and SkateAid Nepal, in Rupandehi district.

The competition was participated by 300 skateboarders from Nepal, India, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, Bhutan, Pakistan and Maldives. They took part in three categories: senior men, senior women and junior men. The competition was for a gold, silver and bronze medal in each category.

Of the total nine medals, Nepali skateboarders won eight – three gold, two silver and three bronze – and dominated the competition.

Sharad Rai, Basanta Rai and Dhiraj Pariyar won the gold, silver and bronze medals in the senior men category respectively. Likewise, Samikshya Rai clinched gold, Khusi BK bagged silver and Swati Shrestha pocketed the bronze medals in the senior women category. In the two categories, the top three players were also awarded with a purse of 1,000, 500 and 250 USD respectively.

On the other hand, India's Mohammad Bin Javed was the only foreign player to win a medal. He claimed the silver medal in the junior men's category where Nepali skateboarders Abhishek Pariyar and Karma Lama Gurung got the gold and bronze medals respectively. The cash prize for the top three was 200, 150 and 100 USD respectively in the junior category.

The players at the top were selected based on their performances in skateboard games and best-run competitions.

Gajendra Bardewa was adjudged the best skateboarder in the competition. He was awarded with a purse of 200 USD.

"Skateboarding is a sport with growing interest throughout South Asia. It should be included in the South Asian Games (SAG)," said Achyut Khanal, chairman of Nepal Skating and Skateboarding Association.



PHOTO: NSC
Skateboarders participate in the South-Asian Skateboard Competition at the Skate Park in Tilottama of Rupandehi district.

Atletico Madrid climb to third in La Liga

AFP
Madrid, Dec. 24

Atletico Madrid climbed to third place in La Liga on Saturday as they beat Sevilla 1-0 despite playing the last 20 minutes with 10 men.

In a match postponed in September because of storms, Marcos Llorente scored the only goal one minute after coming on as a substitute at half time. Llorente pounced when Sevilla centre back Sergio Ramos failed to clear a cross and fired past goalkeeper Marko Dmitrovic from an angle.

Not all coach Diego Simeone's substitutions worked out as well.

Caglar Soyuncu, who had replaced Koke four minutes earlier, earned a straight red card after 70 minutes when he ploughed into Lucas Ocampos from behind.

Simeone reacted by replacing Antoine Griezmann with defender Reinildo Mandava.That left the Frenchman, clearly irritated to be taken off, still tied with Luis Aragones as Atletico's all-time leading scorer on 173 goals.

Griezmann had arrived at the stadium wearing a T-shirt bearing the image of the late Aragones.

Atletico climbed to third in the table, seven points behind leaders Real Madrid and second-placed Girona but ahead of champions Barcelona on goal difference.

Sevilla finish the year in 15th, just three points ahead of Celta Vigo in the first relegation place.

Inter keep Juve at bay

Inter Milan maintained their four-point lead at the top of Serie A with Saturday's 2-0 win over Lecce, as Napoli crashed to a 2-0 defeat at Roma which the troubled champions finished with nine men.

Yann Bissek's first goal in Italy just before half-time at the San Siro and a late finish from Nicolo Barella were enough for Inter to bounce back from cup defeat to Bologna midweek and keep closest challengers Juventus at bay.

The 23-year-old Bissek has had a bumpy start to life at Inter but his header from Hakan Calhanoglu's pinpoint free-kick capped a fine performance at centre-back and sent Inter on the way to a fourth straight league win.

Inter are hunting a 20th league title and look in good shape to do that after beating 12th-placed Lecce without injured star striker Lautaro Martinez.

Dusan Vlahovic kept Juve just about in touch by heading home the decisive goal in a 2-1 win at Frosinone. Napoli fell a whopping 17 points behind Inter after the latest defeat of a disastrous season as Roma reignited their bid for a top four spot.

Substitute Lorenzo Pellegrini lashed in the opener in 76th minute of a ill-tempered, scrappy encounter at the Stadio Olimpico -- which featured 13 bookings and two red cards -- before Romelu Lukaku capped the win deep in stoppage time.

Jose Mourinho's Roma moved into sixth spot above Napoli, whose star striker Victor Osimhen was one of the two players sent off on the day he signed a long-awaited contract extension until 2026.

WEATHER

Monday

Sunrise at 6:52 am, Sunset at 5:16 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Monday)

Partly cloudy in the hilly areas of Koshi Province, Bagmati Province and Gandaki Province and mainly fair in rest of the country.

Expected Temp.: 18 - 20°C
Rain Probability: ...%

Sunday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	17.8	5.1	0.0
Dipayal	24.2	5.9	0.0
Dhangadi	26.7	9.0	0.0
Birendranagar	23.9	6.5	0.0
Nepalgunj	24.6	11.8	0.0
Jumla	18.4	-3.3	0.0
Ghorahi	23.6	9.0	0.0
Pokhara	21.1	8.5	0.0
Bhairahawa	27.4	11.0	0.0
Simara	28.4	13.0	0.0
Kathmandu	18.4	4.9	0.0
Okhaldhunga	18.6	7.8	0.0
Taplejung	17.0	5.6	0.0
Dhankuta	24.2	9.0	0.0
Biratnagar	28.4	11.5	0.0
Jomsom	13.0	-1.5	0.0*
Dharan	28.3	15.0	0.0*
Lumle	17.9	6.7	0.0*
Janakpur	32.2	13.4	0.0*
Jiri	16.0	1.4	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

December 25, 2023

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.73	Rs. 133.33
Euro	1	Rs. 146.16	Rs. 146.82
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 168.59	Rs. 169.35
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 155.11	Rs. 155.81
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 90.26	Rs. 90.66
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 99.99	Rs. 100.44
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 100.26	Rs. 100.71
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 9.32	Rs. 9.36
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.61	Rs. 18.69
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.39	Rs. 35.55
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.42	Rs. 36.59
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.84	Rs. 3.86
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.14	Rs. 36.30
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.66	Rs. 28.78
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 10.22	Rs. 10.27
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 13.27	Rs. 13.33
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.61	Rs. 19.70
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 16.99	Rs. 17.07
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 431.99	Rs. 433.95
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 352.07	Rs. 353.66

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

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Poush 9, 2080 | Nepal Sambat 1144 | Thinllatwho Chaturthi

NATION'S 1ST ENGLISH BROADSHEET

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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

CHRISTMAS DAY GREETINGS

RSS
Kathmandu, Dec. 25

President Ramchandra Paudel and Vice President Ram Sahay Prasad Yadav have wished for happiness, peace and good health to all Christians on the occasion of the Christmas Day.

In a message of greetings, the President said that this festival would help further strengthen our national unity.

The President was of the view that mutual goodwill, tolerance and solidary among diverse cultural identities and religious values would help further strengthen our national unity. President Paudel has added that this festival would deepen aspiration of mutual trust, affection and unity among Nepalis and could make a prosperous Nepal.

In a separate message of greetings, the Vice President has said that the Christmas festival is a social and cultural celebration like other festivals being observed in Nepal.

Similarly, Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has extended best wishes to all Christian communities living in the country and abroad on the occasion of the Christmas Day.

Giving a message of best wishes, PM Prachanda expressed belief that the Christmas will help foster national unity, religious tolerance and social harmony. He reminded that Nepal's constitution has incorporated multicultural diversity. It is common responsibility of all of us to promote unity and tolerance among diverse caste, culture, religion, language and communities, PM Prachanda viewed.

Similarly, the Head of the Government further reminded that globalization has caused intense connectivity and assimilation of human from different countries, communities and cultures across the globe.

LUMBINI CABINET EXPANDED

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Rupandehi, Dec. 24

Lumbini Province Council of Ministers was expanded on Sunday.

Lumbini Province Chief Minister Dilli Bahadur Chaudhary expanded the Council of Ministers by adding two ministers seven months after his appointment as Chief Minister. Now, the province has nine ministers in total.

Krishna KC from CPN (Maoist Centre) has been appointed as Minister of Water Supply, Rural and Cooperatives Development while Saroj Thapa of Nepali Congress has been appointed as Minister for Tourism and Transport.

Lumbini Provincial Chief Amik Sherchan administered the oath of office and secrecy to the new ministers.



PHOTO: PM'S SECRETARIAT

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' directing ministers and officials of Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation and Ministry of Water Supply at a review meeting held in Singha Durbar, Kathmandu on Sunday.

Loan shark victims get back more than 218 bigha of land

BY PURUSHOTTAM P. KHATRI
Kathmandu, Dec. 24

The government's initiatives and actions have now moved towards permanently resolving the cases related to the problems of loan sharking.

The Commission formed to address loan-sharking problems in April this year submitted its report to the government on December 12.

Uttamraj Subedi, one of the members of the Commission and also the Additional Inspector General of Police, shared that since the formation of the Commission, a total of 218 bigha, 10 kattha and 7 dhur (147.6 hectares) of land has been returned to the loan shark victims from their usurious lenders through reconciliation.

The Commission had collected applications from the victims from April 30 to May 28, after it formally began its work from April 9. Altogether 21,552 complaints were lodged from eight districts in Madhes Province while 1,862 complaints were filed from Nawalparasi West.

Commission Chairman Gauri Bahadur Karki said there was no problem of usury in 39 districts.

The government had formed a three-member high-powered Commission to address the issues of loan sharking. The Parliament also had passed the law regarding this and the law has been enforced as well.

The alleged loan sharks who had initially asked for as much as Rs 7.62 billion, have settled for only Rs 1.72 billion during negotiations facilitated by the Commission.

Road to Justice

Over 5,000 cases resolved

According to the Commission, it settled as many as 5,188 complaints of 27,582 through compromise deals. Most complaints originated in eight districts of the Madhes, and the Commission has settled most of these complaints through compromise.

It could settle as many as 3,689 complaints through compromise. As many as 643 complaints were settled in Bara alone, the highest in a district.

Most lenders not only agreed to settle for lower amounts than mentioned in the mortgage documents but also to return the lands the victims claimed were unjustifiably seized by inflating the loan amounts.

According to the Commission, the total loan amount mentioned in the personal mortgage documents in its possession is Rs. 5.57 billion. As a part of the settlement, the lenders also agreed to return over 218 bighas (147.6 hectares) of land which was allegedly seized by artificially inflating loan amounts to the borrowers.

The Commission had little time to settle all the complaints, given the significantly high number, and in many cases, lenders have refused to resolve disputes through compromise.

The Commission suggested the government authorises concerned chief district officers to continue settling disputes through compromise decrees.

Bill criminalises loan sharking

The government, in May, introduced an ordinance criminalising the practice of loan sharking, which greatly helped the Commission settle disputes through compromise between the two sides.

When the ordinance was in force, the Commission warned the lenders that they could be prosecuted if they didn't opt for a compromise.

"As a result, many loan sharks had agreed to settle disputes by withdrawing court cases and promised to return the lands they had seized from borrowers," Karki said.

» SEE PAGE 6

PM emphasises on transparent aircraft purchase deal

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 24

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has instructed the Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation (MoCTCA) not to make any errors or create disputes in the procurement process of aircraft this time and to be more transparent in the process.

Speaking at a joint briefing and discussion with the MoCTCA and the Ministry of Water Supply (MoWS) at the Singh Durbar on Sunday afternoon, PM Prachanda has warned the Ministry not to repeat the past mistakes and push the procurement process into a controversy.

"Procurement of aircraft had always been an issue of controversy and multiple questions were raised every time. I want you not to make a mistake this time. The procurement process should be completely accurate and transparent," he said.

PM Prachanda maintained that some of the policy provisions are not tourist-friendly, so the country should create a comfortable environment for tourists by reforming such policies.

He directed the MoCTCA to bring a proposal to make the necessary changes in the policies.

"Let us attract tourists by opening the prohibited areas. Night service should also be facilitated in tourist areas and the government should be flexible in such initiatives," said PM Prachanda.

He said that on the one hand, negativism has increased so much in the country that no matter how good things are and done, it would be criticised.

"The disease of not seeing the good is increasing. The audience has also become happy with negative words and insults. Apolitical forces with no background, no contribution and no goal are trying to take direct advantage of it. We have to change this situation," he said.

Minister for Water Supply Mahindra Ray Yadav, Minister for Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation Sudan Kirati, Minister of State of Tourism, Sushila Sripali, Chief Secretary of the Government of Nepal Dr. Baikunth Aryal, Secretary of the MoWS Suresh Acharya, Secretary of MoCTCA Deepak Kafle, Finance Secretary Krishna Hari Pushkar and others officials participated in the meeting.

OFFICIALS ASKED TO SOLVE WATER SUPPLY PROBLEM

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 24

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The Prime Minister stated, "I understand that the work in Melamchi is progressing rapidly. A 28-day compact action plan has been created, covering a strategy to deliver 170 million litres of water to Sundarijal within a month. Currently, the work is underway in two shifts. In line with this, the Ministry of Water Supply's leadership and all teams are expected to engage with particular diligence."

He said, "The Kathmandu Valley now has a demand for 250 million litres of water per day. We have also identified and worked on other sources besides Melamchi. Currently, a feasibility study is being conducted to divert 110 million litres of water from the Sisneri River in Makwanpur to the Kathmandu Valley. The ministry will speed up this work as well."

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In the meeting, Minister for Water Supply Mahendra Ray Yadav highlighted the necessity of structural improvements in water supply projects. He expressed the need for simplifying the Public Procurement Regulation, addressing legal issues, and attracting the international community interested in investing in drinking water projects.

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Similarly, the Minister for Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation, Sudan Kiranti said that the airports built under political pressure have not been successful and in the future, airports should be built only based on actual need.

Media should bridge govt and people: Minister Sharma



BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Biratnagar, Dec. 24

Minister for Communication and Information Technology Rekha Sharma has said that the state-owned media should work to build a communication bridge between the people and the government.

After a site visit of the Gorkhapatra Corporation Biratnagar Publication House on Sunday, Minister Sharma pointed out the need for the state-owned media to bring to light people's concerns and aspirations while also covering the government's works and efforts to meet people's aspirations. Stating that such media were more sovereign and freer, she said that they should be more accountable to the public.

Stating that it was crucial to change public opinion towards the state-owned media, Minister Sharma said that one should pay special attention to the content included in the media to change public opinion.

She said that the government was in the process of the formulation of the Public Broadcast Act to bring Radio Nepal and Nepal Television together. She said that due to the lack of factual information, negative perceptions towards state-owned media were being spread and the media were lacking accountability.

Minister Sharma stressed the need for debate on democracy and management, inclusiveness and constitution by Gorkhapatra including other media.

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» SEE PAGE 6

Wildlife menace common near Shivapuri National Park

BY INDIRA ARYAL
Sundarijal, Dec. 24

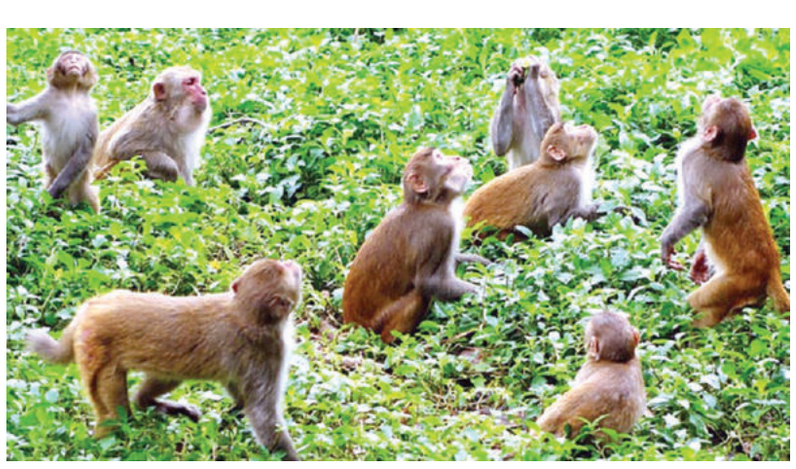
People living in the vicinity of Shivapuri National Park near the capital city are troubled by wildlife menace. They have been dealing with the problems caused by monkeys and wild boars as the farmers of the remote villages.

Because of the expanding forest cover in buffer zones around Shivapuri Nagarjun National Park, the locals are susceptible to the increasing threats posed by wildlife.

The locals are voicing their frustration over the ongoing wildlife menace and the lack of compensation for loss sustained over the past two years.

Sukamaya Gurung from Bhotechaur-3 in Sindhupalchowk district expressed her panic, "We have not received compensation for the damages caused to our crops by the wildlife for the last two years. Even if they offer relief, it is insufficient, they provide only up to Rs. 10,000 as a relief, which is not enough to cover the incurred loss."

"I planted maize in 16 ropanis of land last year, wild boars damaged the crops before we could harvest. Leopards and wild bears also invade our homes. The government should provide us with adequate relief, relocate us from the area, or manage the wildlife within the forest," she said.



Locals cannot go out of their houses alone fearing the leopards and bears, she added.

Meena Gurung of the same ward also has a similar story to share.

Last year, three goats were killed in a leopard attack, she recalled.

"Despite seeking compensation, we have received nothing. The ward chairman is in Manpokhari, and we have presented our problem many times, but our genuine concerns have not been addressed," she said.

"It is challenging for us to stay in the area. We are constantly facing threats from various wild animals, including the common leopard, Himalayan black bear, goral, wild boar, and porcupine. Let's not even mention monkeys, as they come in large numbers and cause havoc."

Surendra Gurung of Haibung in Melamchi Ward No. 3, said that if they could not be relocated from the area, they should be helped grow alternative crops that are resistant to damage from wild animals.

Some people in the village have opted for alternative cash crops like lemons and oranges, but not everyone is in a position to afford the plants, he added.

Narayan Shrestha of the Sundarijal-Shivapuri Consumer Committee said that all the area of the erstwhile Sundarijal Village Development Committee fall inside the buffer zone area. Among them, four villages – Okhreni, Kune, Chilaune and Mulkharka are inside the park.

Villagers complain that leopards and bears are frequently spotted near their houses, though they do not typically attack humans, they pose a threat to cattle. Monkeys and boars are causing immense damage to crops, he informed.

Dr. Ganesh Pant, Chief Conservation Officer of the Park, informed that the park is obligated to pay over Rs. 10 million in compensation annually. The park is in debt, owing Rs. 20 million in compensation for the last two years, which includes complaints from the Forest Office within its jurisdiction. "However, the park received only Rs. 2 million last year," he added.

Locals are currently receiving a maximum compensation of Rs. 10,000 per season for their losses, which is less than the actual damage incurred. Wild boars and monkeys are particularly affecting maize crops. Instances of such destruction have been documented in Kakani in Nuwakot, Gurje in Sindhupalchowk, and Sindhu-Shivapuri in Kathmandu, with reports of similar incidents in other areas as well.

He said that while the area has traditionally been a bear habitat, conflicts were rare until recently. Recent issues have surfaced outside the protected area in Gurjebahngyang, Nuwakot, leading residents to seek park assistance. In response, the park conducted monitoring, with no reported losses. However, a an incident occurred in Sundarijal during Dashain.

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Monday, December 25, 2023
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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

CHRISTMAS DAY GREETINGS

RSS
Kathmandu, Dec. 25

President Ramchandra Paudel and Vice President Ram Sahay Prasad Yadav have wished for happiness, peace and good health to all Christians on the occasion of the Christmas Day.

In a message of greetings, the President said that this festival would help further strengthen our national unity.

The President was of the view that mutual goodwill, tolerance and solidary among diverse cultural identities and religious values would help further strengthen our national unity. President Paudel has added that this festival would deepen aspiration of mutual trust, affection and unity among Nepalis and could make a prosperous Nepal.

In a separate message of greetings, the Vice President has said that the Christmas festival is a social and cultural celebration like other festivals being observed in Nepal.

Similarly, Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has extended best wishes to all Christian communities living in the country and abroad on the occasion of the Christmas Day.

Giving a message of best wishes, PM Prachanda expressed belief that the Christmas will help foster national unity, religious tolerance and social harmony. He reminded that Nepal's constitution has incorporated multicultural diversity. It is common responsibility of all of us to promote unity and tolerance among diverse caste, culture, religion, language and communities, PM Prachanda viewed.

Similarly, the Head of the Government further reminded that globalization has caused intense connectivity and assimilation of human from different countries, communities and cultures across the globe.

LUMBINI CABINET EXPANDED

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Rupandehi, Dec. 24

Lumbini Province Council of Ministers was expanded on Sunday.

Lumbini Province Chief Minister Dilli Bahadur Chaudhary expanded the Council of Ministers by adding two ministers seven months after his appointment as Chief Minister. Now, the province has nine ministers in total.

Krishna KC from CPN (Maoist Centre) has been appointed as Minister of Water Supply, Rural and Cooperatives Development while Saroj Thapa of Nepali Congress has been appointed as Minister for Tourism and Transport.

Lumbini Provincial Chief Amik Sherchan administered the oath of office and secrecy to the new ministers.



PHOTO: PM'S SECRETARIAT

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' directing ministers and officials of Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation and Ministry of Water Supply at a review meeting held in Singha Durbar, Kathmandu on Sunday.

Loan shark victims get back more than 218 bigha of land

BY PURUSHOTTAM P. KHATRI
Kathmandu, Dec. 24

The government's initiatives and actions have now moved towards permanently resolving the cases related to the problems of loan sharking.

The Commission formed to address loan-sharking problems in April this year submitted its report to the government on December 12.

Uttamraj Subedi, one of the members of the Commission and also the Additional Inspector General of Police, shared that since the formation of the Commission, a total of 218 bigha, 10 kattha and 7 dhur (147.6 hectares) of land has been returned to the loan shark victims from their usurious lenders through reconciliation.

The Commission had collected applications from the victims from April 30 to May 28, after it formally began its work from April 9. Altogether 21,552 complaints were lodged from eight districts in Madhes Province while 1,862 complaints were filed from Nawalparasi West.

Commission Chairman Gauri Bahadur Karki said there was no problem of usury in 39 districts.

The government had formed a three-member high-powered Commission to address the issues of loan sharking. The Parliament also had passed the law regarding this and the law has been enforced as well.

The alleged loan sharks who had initially asked for as much as Rs 7.62 billion, have settled for only Rs 1.72 billion during negotiations facilitated by the Commission.

Road to Justice

Over 5,000 cases resolved

According to the Commission, it settled as many as 5,188 complaints of 27,582 through compromise deals. Most complaints originated in eight districts of the Madhes, and the Commission has settled most of these complaints through compromise.

It could settle as many as 3,689 complaints through compromise. As many as 643 complaints were settled in Bara alone, the highest in a district.

Most lenders not only agreed to settle for lower amounts than mentioned in the mortgage documents but also to return the lands the victims claimed were unjustifiably seized by inflating the loan amounts.

According to the Commission, the total loan amount mentioned in the personal mortgage documents in its possession is Rs. 5.57 billion. As a part of the settlement, the lenders also agreed to return over 218 bighas (147.6 hectares) of land which was allegedly seized by artificially inflating loan amounts to the borrowers.

The Commission had little time to settle all the complaints, given the significantly high number, and in many cases, lenders have refused to resolve disputes through compromise.

The Commission suggested the government authorises concerned chief district officers to continue settling disputes through compromise decrees.

Bill criminalises loan sharking

The government, in May, introduced an ordinance criminalising the practice of loan sharking, which greatly helped the Commission settle disputes through compromise between the two sides.

When the ordinance was in force, the Commission warned the lenders that they could be prosecuted if they didn't opt for a compromise.

"As a result, many loan sharks had agreed to settle disputes by withdrawing court cases and promised to return the lands they had seized from borrowers," Karki said.

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PM emphasises on transparent aircraft purchase deal

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 24

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has instructed the Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation (MoCTCA) not to make any errors or create disputes in the procurement process of aircraft this time and to be more transparent in the process.

Speaking at a joint briefing and discussion with the MoCTCA and the Ministry of Water Supply (MoWS) at the Singh Durbar on Sunday afternoon, PM Prachanda has warned the Ministry not to repeat the past mistakes and push the procurement process into a controversy.

"Procurement of aircraft had always been an issue of controversy and multiple questions were raised every time. I want you not to make a mistake this time. The procurement process should be completely accurate and transparent," he said.

PM Prachanda maintained that some of the policy provisions are not tourist-friendly, so the country should create a comfortable environment for tourists by reforming such policies.

He directed the MoCTCA to bring a proposal to make the necessary changes in the policies.

"Let us attract tourists by opening the prohibited areas. Night service should also be facilitated in tourist areas and the government should be flexible in such initiatives," said PM Prachanda.

He said that on the one hand, negativism has increased so much in the country that no matter how good things are and done, it would be criticised.

"The disease of not seeing the good is increasing. The audience has also become happy with negative words and insults. Apolitical forces with no background, no contribution and no goal are trying to take direct advantage of it. We have to change this situation," he said.

Minister for Water Supply Mahindra Ray Yadav, Minister for Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation Sudan Kirati, Minister of State of Tourism, Sushila Sripali, Chief Secretary of the Government of Nepal Dr. Baikunth Aryal, Secretary of the MoWS Suresh Acharya, Secretary of MoCTCA Deepak Kafle, Finance Secretary Krishna Hari Pushkar and others officials participated in the meeting.

OFFICIALS ASKED TO SOLVE WATER SUPPLY PROBLEM

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